

James



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF PERCIVAL EVERETT

Percival Everett was born in Fort Gordon, Georgia, where his father was stationed as a sergeant in the United States Army. His family moved to Columbia, South Carolina when he was young. Everett graduated from the University of Miami with a bachelor's degree in philosophy and earned his master's degree in fiction from Brown University in 1982. Everett's literary career is wide-ranging in terms of genre and theme: he has written westerns, mythological retellings, philosophical fiction, thrillers, mysteries, and satire. His most well-known novel, *Erasure* (2001), is a metafictional work satirizing the publishing industry's tendency to pigeonhole Black authors. In 2023, the novel was adapted into the film *American Fiction*, which won Best Adapted Screenplay at the Academy Awards. Other notable works include *I Am Not Sidney Poitier* (2009)—a novel whose protagonist bears a physical resemblance to actor Sidney Poitier and that explores issues of racial segregation and identity—and *The Trees* (2021)—a novel about historical and contemporary lynchings. *The Trees* won the Anisfield-Wolf Book Award and was shortlisted for the 2022 Booker Prize. Everett teaches as a Distinguished Professor of English at the University of Southern California. He lives in Los Angeles with his wife, Danzy Senna, and family.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

From the 15th century until the 19th century, the transatlantic slave trade forcibly imported around 12 million Africans to European colonies, primarily in North and South America. The United States participated in the international slave trade from the country's conception in 1776 until 1807, when federal law prohibited the importation of more enslaved people to the United States. While many found ways to smuggle Africans into the country despite this law, in the years after 1808, the United States primarily engaged in the domestic slave trade, relocating over one million enslaved people to the Deep South. In the 1850s, political tensions rose between the northern states—who sought to abolish slavery—and the southern states—who relied on slave labor to fuel their economy. The formation of the Underground Railroad—a secret network of routes and houses—provided a way for enslaved people to escape their abusive owners by fleeing to the north. The 1860 election of President Abraham Lincoln brought the conflict to a head, leading seven southern slave states to secede from the Union and found the Confederacy. War broke out in April 1861 and lasted until 1865, claiming the lives of over one million citizens. While the southern states ultimately rejoined the

Union, and enslaved people in the Confederacy were gradually emancipated, there is much debate over the causes and motivations of the Civil War. Like Jim, many believe the abolition of slavery was an incidental outcome of the war rather than a primary motivation.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Mark Twain's 1885 novel, *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, serves as Everett's source text and is the sequel to [The Adventures of Tom Sawyer](#) (1876). As in *James* (2024), Twain's novel pays close attention to themes of vernacular language and social satire but is complicated by its extensive use of racial stereotypes and slurs. Everett's 2001 novel *Erasure* further investigates themes of language and racial identity, focusing his satirical critique this time on the publishing industry. For readers wishing to delve deeper into Jim's side of Huck Finn's narrative, Nancy Rawles's *My Jim* (2005) explores the perspective of Jim's wife, Sadie, as she copes with the devastating loss of her husband. Jean Toomer's surreal collection of poetry and vignettes, titled *Cane* (1923), examines the experiences of Black Americans who use code-switching and racial performance to remain safe in white spaces. For those interested in literature which reckons with authors who were both popular and problematic, Mat Johnson's *Pym* (2011) examines an obscure novel by Edgar Allan Poe from the perspective of a Black professor who embarks on an epic journey into frigid and racially fraught territory. Lastly, Colson Whitehead's National Book Award-winning novel [The Underground Railroad](#) (2016) follows a Black woman's harrowing escape from enslavement and examines the lasting ramifications of America's horrific slave trade, which persist in the present day.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** James
- **Where Written:** United States
- **When Published:** 2024
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel, Historical Fiction, Satire
- **Setting:** 1860s United States
- **Climax:** James reveals to Judge Thatcher that he can read and forces the judge to assist him in finding his family.
- **Antagonist:** The institution of slavery; anti-Black racism
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Own Voices. Everett did not write *James* (2024) to address any deficiencies in *Huckleberry Finn* (1885), but instead imagines himself in conversation with Twain. By writing Jim's perspective, Everett accesses a side of the story that was unavailable to Twain as a white man.

Coded Language. In interviews, Everett frequently mentions his belief that oppressed people always find a way to communicate to each other in ways their oppressors cannot understand. He takes issue with the movie [12 Years a Slave](#) (2013) for the way its main character—a free Black man raised in the North—is able to understand the enslaved Black people he finds himself imprisoned alongside, insisting they would speak in their own coded language.



PLOT SUMMARY

James is a retelling of Mark Twain's *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* (1885) from the perspective of Jim, an enslaved Black man whose escape parallels and overlaps with young Huck's journey. Before Jim's narrative begins, there is a selection of song lyrics purportedly taken from "The Notebook of Daniel Decatur Emmett." Emmett is a historical figure, a musician and composer who founded the first troupe of the blackface minstrel tradition, the Virginia Minstrels. His songs make use of an exaggerated vernacular intended to mimic the diction of enslaved Black people.

In Hannibal, Missouri, Jim hears Huck Finn and Tom Sawyer spying on him as he waits for his owner, Miss Watson. Jim pretends to be asleep, allowing Huck and Tom to play a prank on him. Later, he tells the other enslaved men about this prank in earshot of the boys, furthering their amusement. Whenever Jim and the other enslaved people are near a white person, they speak in a stereotypical slave dialect, but they speak normally when they are alone. Jim spends his evenings instructing enslaved children, like his own daughter, Lizzie, in what he calls "slave talk." This language fulfills racist white people's expectations of enslaved people, feeding the illusion that they are simple and submissive—and this deception, the novel intimates, can be essential for survival. In reality, Jim has taught himself to read using the [books](#) in Judge Thatcher's office.

Huck, who lives in Miss Watson's care, frequently makes conversation with Jim. Jim hears news that Huck's abusive father, Pap Finn, is back in town, and he worries for the boy's safety, even though he is white. One day, Jim's wife, Sadie, overhears Miss Watson making plans to sell Jim, which will separate him from his family. Jim decides to run away and hide out nearby until he can find a way to reunite with Sadie and Lizzie.

Jim makes camp on Jackson Island in the Mississippi River,

where he runs into Huck, who has faked his own death to escape his father's cruelty. One night, a massive storm hits the island and an entire house floats downriver. Jim and Huck search the house and discover a dead body, but only Jim gets a close look at the man. A rattlesnake bites Jim, and he descends into a fever dream in which he argues with the French writer Voltaire about his problematic views on human equality and the institution of slavery. When Jim recovers, Huck remarks that he was sleep talking in a strange diction. Huck returns to the mainland disguised as a girl to seek out news about Sadie and Lizzie. Jim contemplates telling Huck that the dead man in the house was Pap, but he decides against it. Huck returns but is worried he was followed, so the two sail away from the island.

Huck and Jim travel along the river under cover of darkness, making camp on the shore during the day. They steal a skiff from some robbers. Jim is thrilled to find stolen [books](#) aboard, although he must pretend to be illiterate in front of Huck. After a close call with some white men who are looking for Jim, their raft breaks apart in another storm, separating them.

Washed ashore, Jim meets some other enslaved men named Josiah, Old George, Young George, and Pierre. He asks them to find a [pencil](#) for him, and Young George steals one from his master. In his hideout, Jim reads his [books](#) and practices writing, beginning a narrative account of his own life. One night, Jim witnesses an overseer whipping Young George for the theft of the pencil. He runs and reunites with Huck, who has become embroiled in a bloody saga between feuding families. Together, they take to the river once more.

Jim and Huck encounter the Duke and the King, two conmen escaping the consequences of their most recent lies. The group visits a small town, where the King and the Duke attempt to swindle money out of the townsfolk but are caught. Jim and Huck abandon the grifters to their fate, but the men catch up to them soon after. Knowing now that Jim is a runaway, they scheme to sell him and then have him escape so that they can repeat the scheme again and again. This plan falls apart when the Duke assaults Easter, an enslaved man belonging to Wiley. Jim stays behind to repay the Duke's debt. Daniel Decatur Emmett hears Jim singing while he works and buys him from Wiley for 200 dollars to be the new tenor in his musical troupe, the Virginia Minstrels.

Emmett's minstrels travel from town to town, performing original songs in blackface. Jim is the only member who is visibly Black, and because of this, he must pretend to be a white man disguised as a Black man. Norman is the only other Black minstrel, though he passes for white among the public and the rest of the troupe. After Jim's first show, the authenticity of Jim's appearance raises suspicions, and the minstrels leave abruptly. Although Emmett claims he has hired Jim, he views him as an indentured servant, which amounts to another form of enslavement. When the rest of the minstrels perform in the next town, Jim steals Emmett's songbook and runs again.

Norman catches up with Jim, and they travel together. Jim begins writing his narrative in Emmett's songbook (based on the lyrics that began the novel, the reader now realizes that this narrative is what they are reading). Passing as a white slaveowner, Norman sells Jim to a man called Henderson. Jim escapes, taking a young girl named Sammy with him, but she is shot and killed while running. Jim and Norman sneak aboard a riverboat, where they encounter Brock, an enslaved man who never leaves the vessel's engine room. On the upper decks, Norman hears news of a war brewing between the northern and southern states. Suddenly, the riverboat explodes. In the water, Jim hears both Norman and Huck calling his name.

Jim chooses to save Huck because—he reveals—the boy is his biological son. Huck feels his identity is now complicated, but Jim urges him to continue passing as white to avoid the suffering of enslavement. They return to Hannibal, Missouri and discover that Sadie and Lizzie have been sold. Jim hides out in his old house and witnesses the overseer, Hopkins, raping an enslaved woman named Katie. Jim returns to Jackson Island to wait for Huck, who is trying to find out who bought Sadie and Lizzie. While there, he encounters a drunk Hopkins alone and kills him. Huck brings word that Sadie and Lizzie have been sold to Graham farm before returning to town.

Jim sails to the mainland and sneaks into Judge Thatcher's office, hoping to find his family's bill of sale. The judge catches him in the act, but Jim threatens Thatcher with Hopkins's gun. Thatcher is frightened by Jim's eloquent speech and his lack of fear. Jim leaves the judge tied to a tree, having obtained directions to Graham farm.

Jim reaches Graham farm and finds several enslaved men tied to a post. He frees them and asks if they would like to run or join him in a revolt. They choose the latter. The men set fire to the cornfield, overpower the overseer, and tell everyone to run. Reunited with Sadie and Lizzie, Jim shoots the farm's owner before he and his family flee north. Eventually, they arrive in Iowa and are given safe harbor, thanks to the ongoing war. Jim tells the authorities that his name is James.

to pacify white expectations, demonstrating a deep understanding of racism and a commitment to survival. Despite his ability to feel sympathy for white people (like Huck), Jim finds the hypocrisy of white humanitarian philosophers like Voltaire and John Locke disillusioning. Interactions with men like the Duke, the King, and Daniel Decatur Emmett increase Jim's sense that white people find the idea of Black equality and humanity unacceptable. While reuniting his family is Jim's primary goal, he also endeavors to reclaim his agency by writing a narrative of his life using a **pencil** stolen by Young George and rechristening himself "James." By the novel's end, Jim has learned to befriend his righteous anger and put it to use in what he views as the "state of war" in which enslaved Black people find themselves.

Huck – Huckleberry Finn is a young boy who lives in the care of Miss Watson. He is the close friend of Tom Sawyer. While Huck was raised believing Pap Finn and Huck's mother are his parents, Jim eventually reveals that he is Huck's biological father, making the boy biracial. Until Huck learns the truth, he treats Jim as a friend and frequently pesters him with questions. Huck fakes his own death in an attempt to flee from his abusive father, and he travels with Jim along the Mississippi River. Huck is primarily characterized as innocent. As a young boy growing up in the South just before the Civil War, Huck finds himself caught in the tension between his own whiteness and Black enslavement. He often expresses discomfort with the practice of slavery, especially around Jim, who he understands is a human being, capable of feeling all the same things he feels. When Huck learns the truth about Jim, he feels betrayed and goes through an identity crisis, unsure whether he is Black or white. Though Huck chooses to continue to pass as a white boy in the end, he plays an integral role in helping Jim recover his family, and he goes on to support the Union in the Civil War.

Norman – Norman is a Black man whose complexion is light enough for him to pass as a white person. While he escaped his enslaver, his wife was left behind. Norman works for Daniel Decatur Emmett's Virginia Minstrels in the hopes of raising enough money to buy his wife from her enslaver. As the only other Black minstrel, Norman sees through Jim's "slave talk" and understands his frustration with being Emmett's indentured servant. Norman is deeply conflicted about his ability to pass as a white person, even when he uses it to his advantage, as when he disguises himself as Jim's enslaver. He tells Sammy that he still identifies as a Black man because he does not want to be white, associating whiteness with dehumanizing cruelty. By the end of the novel, Jim feels partially responsible for Norman's death, having chosen to save Huck from drowning instead of Norman.

Daniel Decatur Emmett – Daniel Decatur Emmett is a historical figure, a musician and composer who founded the first blackface minstrel troupe, the Virginia Minstrels. His songs are written in what Emmett perceives as Black dialect, making



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

James (Jim) – James is an enslaved Black man in his late 20s. Although his enslavers named him "Jim," he eventually renames himself "James." He is Sadie's husband and Lizzie's father. Miss Watson is Jim's enslaver who looks after Huck—a young white boy who befriends Jim and travels with him along the Mississippi River. Near the novel's end, it is revealed that Jim is Huck's biological father, as he was close with Huck's mother. Jim is resourceful, intelligent, and compassionate. He teaches himself and other enslaved people to read using the **books** in Judge Thatcher's library, but he uses stereotypical slave diction

use of incorrect grammar and simplistic themes that romanticize Black lives of enslavement. In the novel, Emmett hears Jim singing for Wiley and pays 200 dollars to “hire” him as the troupe’s tenor. Emmett claims he is morally opposed to slavery and insists that he has employed Jim rather than purchasing him. Nevertheless, he demands that Jim work for him long enough to pay him back, effectively making Jim an indentured servant. When Jim runs away with Emmett’s songbook, Emmett reacts with a racist tirade, proving that he does not actually view Black people as human beings.

Voltaire – Voltaire is a French writer and philosopher who lived during the 18th century’s Age of Enlightenment. Jim hallucinates Voltaire in a fever dream after he is bitten by a rattlesnake. He takes issue with Voltaire’s contradictory statements regarding human equality and the inferiority of certain races. Voltaire’s presence points to Jim’s frustration with the hypocrisy of alleged abolitionists who treat the institution of slavery like a thought experiment rather than reality.

John Locke – John Locke is an influential English philosopher and writer who lived during the 18th century’s Age of Enlightenment. Jim dreams about and hallucinates Locke during his journey, and he confronts the hypocrisy of his writings, which both criticize and condone slavery. Like Voltaire, Locke’s presence allows Jim to critique the alleged defenders of his humanity, thereby defending it himself.

The Duke – The Duke is a young conman who claims he is the rightful Duke of Bridgewater. He joins Huck, Jim, and the King on their journey after he is run out of town for selling a defective toothpaste. Conniving and violent, the Duke beats Jim and assaults Easter. He views Black people as less than human.

The King – The King is an elderly conman who claims he is Dauphin, the son of Louis XVI and Marie Antoinette, and the rightful king of France. He joins Huck, Jim, and the Duke after he is run out of the town where he has been preaching the evils of drinking, having been discovered partaking in alcohol himself. The King is manipulative and crafty. He and the Duke come up with the plan to sell Jim repeatedly.

Lizzie – Lizzie is the daughter of Jim and Sadie. Like her parents, she is enslaved by Miss Watson. She and the other enslaved children learn how to speak “slave talk” from Jim, to pacify their white abusers. Young Sammy reminds Jim of Lizzie, prompting him to take her with him when he runs from Henderson. Reuniting with Lizzie and Sadie is Jim’s primary motivation.

Young George – Young George is an enslaved Black man who Jim meets after he is separated from Huck. He works alongside Josiah, Old George, and Pierre. At Jim’s request, Young George steals a **pencil** from his enslaver but is discovered and killed for the crime. Jim frequently draws on Young George’s memory

when he uses the pencil to write.

Sammy – Sammy is a young enslaved Black woman who works at Henderson’s mill, though Jim mistakes her for a man at first. Henderson has sexually abused Sammy, and she decides to take her chances with Jim rather than continue to endure her enslaver’s torment. Sammy reminds Jim of his daughter, Lizzie, and her death leaves him deeply affected.

Judge Thatcher – Judge Thatcher is the local judge in Hannibal, Missouri. He and Miss Watson look after Huck’s welfare in Pap’s absence. Jim teaches himself to read using the **books** in Judge Thatcher’s library. Jim’s confrontation with the judge forms the novel’s climax. Thatcher’s horror at Jim’s ability to read emphasizes the novel’s idea that the performance of ignorance puts white people at ease and causes them to underestimate Black people.

Easter – Easter is an enslaved blacksmith. Huck and Jim meet him when they’re under the control of the King and the Duke, who convince Easter to shackle Jim while they leave for the night. Sympathetic to Jim’s plight, Easter unshackles him when the King and the Duke leave, and they spend the night commiserating with one another. At one point, Easter implies that he can tell Huck isn’t fully white, but Jim gets him to drop the subject. Nonetheless, Huck is disarmed by hearing Easter and Jim drop their “slave talk.” When the King and the Duke eventually return to find Jim unshackled, they whip Easter, which enrages Easter’s enslaver, Mr. Wiley, who says Jim must work for him until Easter recovers. As a result, the King and the Duke leave Jim behind, separating him from Huck.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Sadie – Sadie is Jim’s wife and Lizzie’s mother. Miss Watson is her enslaver. It is Sadie who hears Miss Watson’s plan to sell Jim, prompting his escape. Reuniting with her and Lizzie is Jim’s primary motivation.

Josiah – Josiah is an enslaved Black man whom Jim meets on his journey. He works alongside Old George, Young George, and Pierre. Josiah has escaped from his enslaver many times but has always been caught and beaten.

Pap Finn – Pap Finn is Huck’s alleged father, who was married to Huck’s mother before she died. He is an alcoholic whose abuse drives Huck to fake his own death. Pap has a particular hatred for Jim, perhaps because he knows Jim is Huck’s biological father.

Miss Watson – Miss Watson is the enslaver of Jim, Sadie, Lizzie, and many others. She looks after Huck while Pap is absent. Her plan to sell Jim pushes him to run away.

Tom Sawyer – Tom Sawyer is a young white boy who is friends with Huck. He likes to play pranks, particularly on Jim. His wild tales and bossy attitude sometimes get on Huck’s nerves.

Huck’s Mom – Huck’s mom is Huckleberry Finn’s mother.

Though she was married to Pap, she was close friends with Jim, who is Huck's biological father.

Luke – Luke is an enslaved Black man who works at Henderson's mill. When Jim meets him, he is struck by Luke's submissive demeanor. Convinced that Luke enjoys his own enslavement, Jim does not trust him.

Henderson – Henderson is a white millowner and enslaver who purchases Jim from Norman. He has enslaved many others, including Luke and Sammy. Henderson is a violent man who likes to beat his slave for no reason at all, and he sexually abuses Sammy.

Brock – Brock is an enslaved Black man who works in a riverboat's boiler room and never leaves. Jim finds Brock's enthusiastic submission to his enslavement unsettling.

Cunégonde – Cunégonde is a character in Voltaire's 1759 novel [Candide](#). Jim dreams of her as he ponders how to reunite his family, and she tells him that hope is a ruse. Cunégonde claims that, while Jim may escape slavery, he will never be free.

Old George – Old George is an enslaved Black man who works alongside Josiah, Young George, and Pierre. Jim meets him after he is separated from Huck.

Pierre – Pierre is an enslaved Black man who works alongside Old George, Young George, and Josiah. He is initially suspicious of Jim, worried he will bring trouble into their midst.

Katie – Katie is an enslaved Black woman who is married to Cotton. She lives on Miss Watson's property in the house Jim's family vacated. Hopkins, the overseer, routinely sexually assaults her.

Hopkins – Hopkins is an overseer employed by Miss Watson. He sexually assaults Katie while Jim is hidden in her cabin. After murdering Hopkins, Jim wonders what else his anger is capable of.

Cotton – Cotton is an enslaved Black man who is married to Katie. He lives on Miss Watson's property in the house Jim's family vacated.

Old Luke – Old Luke is an enslaved Black man who works for Miss Watson alongside Jim.

Doris – Doris is an enslaved Black man who works for Miss Watson alongside Jim.

Albert – Albert is an enslaved Black man who works for Miss Watson alongside Jim.

Norman's Wife – Norman's wife is an enslaved Black woman who is married to Norman. Norman works in the hopes of purchasing his wife's freedom.

Polly – Polly is a white woman who speaks to Jim after his first performance with Daniel Decatur Emmett's Virginia Minstrels. Polly's father finds the authenticity of Jim's makeup suspicious.

Polly's Father – Polly's father is a white man who accompanies his daughter to the Virginia Minstrels' performance. He

suspects that Jim is actually Black underneath his makeup, driving Emmett and the rest of the troupe out of town.

Cassidy – Cassidy is a white man who plays trombone in Emmett's troupe.

Big Mike – Big Mike is a white man who performs with Emmett's troupe.

Mr. Wiley – Mr. Wiley is Easter's enslaver. When the King and the Duke injure Easter, Mr. Wiley furiously says Jim must work for him until Easter recovers. The King and the Duke acquiesce and leave with Huck, thus separating him from Jim.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



SPEECH, PERFORMANCE, AND WILLFUL IGNORANCE

Throughout *James*, the titular character—referred to as Jim for most of the novel—uses language as a mode of performance. Whenever white people are present, Jim and other enslaved Black people speak in what they call “slave talk”—a heightened diction intended to support the prevalent white view that Black people are less intelligent. On their own, though, Jim and the others speak more fluently and naturally, and they can effortlessly switch between the two languages depending on their audience. The reason behind this act is simple but crucial: as Jim instructs a group of enslaved children, “White folks expect us to sound a certain way and it can only help if we don’t disappoint them.” Enslaved Black people have learned that performing the white expectation of their racial inferiority is the best way to remain safe, whereas disappointing that expectation can have dire consequences. Here, the novel examines how Black safety is often dependent upon white comfort, even when that comfort is based on the false notion of racial superiority.

The character Daniel Decatur Emmett introduces another kind of performance to the novel, as he leads the Virginia Minstrels, a musical troupe of white men wearing blackface. When Emmett purchases Jim to sing with the group, the depth of Jim's performance doubles: in order to keep white audiences comfortable with his presence among the minstrels, he must pretend to be a white man wearing blackface. On top of this, Jim must maintain his own façade of stereotypical slave talk in front of the other white musicians, though this, too, is complicated by the presence of Norman—a Black man who passes for white. Eventually, these layers of performance overwhelm Jim, who—in a moment of panic—says “I didn’t know

how or what to scream.” In this way, the novel shows that Jim’s double life—though necessary for his survival—has become unsustainable.

Ultimately, the way Jim polices his own speech to preserve white comfort keeps neither him nor his family safe. Despite his “correct incorrect grammar,” Miss Watson decides to sell Jim, and his situation only worsens after running away. Realizing this, Jim eventually abandons slave talk, speaking to Judge Thatcher at the novel’s climax in his normal voice. That the judge is more disturbed by Jim’s language than his crimes shows how the appearance of Black inferiority is integral to the white slaveholder’s worldview. Confronted with the truth of Jim’s intelligence and personhood, Thatcher and others like him must reckon with their own moral failing of enslaving their equals.



IDENTITY, NARRATIVE, AND AGENCY

As a reimagining of Mark Twain’s *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, *James* seeks to reclaim that narrative for its eponymous character by centering

the perspective of the frequently stereotyped enslaved Black man. While Jim has been taught that his identity is irrevocably tied to his enslavement, even before the novel begins, he has taken measures to redefine himself on his own terms by learning to read and write. Jim’s struggle with his identity is often rooted in language—the first words he writes with his **pencil** are “I am called Jim. I have yet to choose a name.” Here, he distinguishes himself from the name his enslavers gave to him, demonstrating the desire for an identity of his own making. Additionally, Jim is not content to read the words of white men or even other slaves—his request that Young George steal the pencil for him points to a deep need to construct his own narrative. The fact that the pencil’s theft leads to Young George’s murder does not dissuade Jim from his authorial pursuits—on the contrary, the pencil becomes his most prized possession and serves as a constant reminder that self-determination is something worth dying for.

It’s also worth considering the revelation that Huck is Jim’s biological son, since this revelation causes the boy to have an identity crisis. One moment, Huck embraces this new self-knowledge by attempting to use “slave talk,” and the next, he is furiously declaring that he is not an n-word. Familiar with his own need for agency, Jim tells Huck, “You can be what you want to be.” Later, considering why he told Huck the truth when he didn’t need to, Jim reflects that he “needed for [Huck] to have a choice.” This seems to imply that, without the full knowledge of his racial identity, Huck wouldn’t be able to fully exercise his sense of personal agency. Ultimately, Huck continues passing as white but deepens his compassion for enslaved Black people, siding with the Union army. Despite these developments, Huck’s shifting identity is secondary to Jim’s narrative, which ends with him officially claiming the name “James” and writing

his own story. By allowing James to write his own retelling of his travels with Huck, the novel returns agency to a character who has been historically stripped of the ability to control his own narrative.



RACISM, DEHUMANIZATION, AND HYPOCRISY

Through Jim’s interactions with white people and his hallucinated encounters with famous

philosophers and writers, *James* examines how racism and enslavement inherently involve the hypocritical denial of another person’s humanity. Throughout the novel, white characters frequently refer to Jim as if he is something other than a human being. While beating Jim, the Duke declares that “he ain’t no proper people. He don’t feel pain like we do.” It is worth noting that, by suggesting that Black people have a higher pain tolerance than white people, the Duke is seeking to justify his own violent actions. Later, Norman (pretending to be Jim’s owner) tells a white woman that Jim is incapable of human speech, and she compares him to a trained monkey. Here, the novel demonstrates that this kind of dehumanization is a way that white people try to justify abuse and enslavement.

Jim’s encounters with white characters who claim to oppose slavery reveal that, more often than not, such sentiments are insincere and unsupported by action. Daniel Decatur Emmett attempts to claim a moral high ground by declaring that he has hired Jim rather than purchasing him. Jim sees through this ruse even before Emmett reveals that Jim cannot leave until his debt is paid back, making him a severely underpaid indentured servant (which essentially amounts to enslavement in terms of Jim’s freedom). Similarly, Jim’s imagined conversations with philosophers like Voltaire and John Locke demonstrate a disappointing trend of hypocrisy, in which the writers’ alleged commitment to human equality falters when the discussion turns to slaves. Inevitably, such philosophers dehumanize Black people in order to justify racial subjugation for the benefit of white people—for example, Voltaire asserts that “African humans” contain “the presence of [...] the devil.” Jim repeatedly refutes both Voltaire and Locke’s insistence on casting slavery as a moral gray area, and the novel explores their self-serving hypocrisy. In this way, the novel shows how the process of dehumanizing another human being to justify poor treatment inevitably compromises one’s own moral code.



INNOCENCE VS. DISILLUSIONMENT

Throughout *James*, Huck’s youthful innocence sharply contrasts with Jim’s increasing worldly disillusionment. As in Twain’s novel, *Huckleberry*

Finn is a mischief-maker with a fondness for adventure. The novel begins with him and Tom Sawyer playing a prank on Jim, who plays along because “[i]t always pays to give white folks

what they want.” Despite lumping Huck in with other “white folks,” Jim feels genuine sympathy for the boy, telling Old Luke, “He’s just trying to figure things out. Like the rest of us, I guess.” During their travels together, Jim frequently notes Huck’s sincerity and innocence, as when the boy considers saving the Duke and the King, even though they are criminals and intend to turn Jim in as a runaway. Jim attributes Huck’s guileless nature to his youth, suggesting that children are more empathetic and morally pure than adults. It is worth noting, however, that Huck runs away out of fear of his abusive father, Pap, hinting that no person can remain untouched by the world’s suffering forever.

As the novel progresses, Jim himself becomes more and more disillusioned with the world that has enslaved him. Forced to bear the indignities and violence of enslavement, Jim possesses the cynicism and distrust necessary for his own survival. He is as suspicious of the intentions of white people as they are of him, with good reason—even those who claim to oppose slavery, like Emmett, do not treat Jim as an equal. After encountering slaves like Luke and Brock, who joyfully submit to their degradation, Jim even struggles to extend compassion to other Black people, uncertain if they can be trusted. By the novel’s end, Jim is more than willing to kill Hopkins after he witnesses the overseer raping Katie. After the murder, he discovers that he feels no guilt. Rather than feeling disturbed by his newfound apathy, Jim wonders “what else I was capable of doing.” By the novel’s end, Jim’s suffering has stripped him of much of his hope, though he clings to his desire to free his family and write his own story. By juxtaposing Huck’s innocence with Jim’s descent into cold disillusionment, the novel investigates how suffering injustice can—understandably—lead people to become cynical and isolated.



FAMILY, ALLIANCE, AND LOYALTY

As opposed to Twain’s novel, which focuses on Huck’s whimsical adventures along the Mississippi, *James* highlights a darker narrative: Jim’s struggle to free himself, his wife, Sadie, and his daughter, Lizzie from slavery. Jim’s family is his primary motivation for running away from the threat of being sold, as he does not want to be permanently separated from them. Connection—familial or otherwise—also plays a central role in many of the novel’s side plots. Jim forms an alliance with Norman, who is in a similar situation, hoping to buy his wife from her enslaver in Virginia. He tries hard to free Sammy, an abused young woman who reminds him of his own daughter. Of course, there is also Jim’s friendship with Huck, a particular connection amplified by the hidden truth that they are father and son. By emphasizing the importance of these alliances and connections, the novel highlights how interpersonal relationships can sustain a person through times of great suffering.

Characters like Emmett and Judge Thatcher call attention to a different kind of relationship—that is, the relationship between oppressor and victim (or, as Jim might say, between enemies). Despite the violence inherent to the institution of slavery, both men assume Jim is loyal to them simply because they do not treat him with extreme cruelty. Despite Emmett’s declaration that Jim is his employee—not his property—the man is furious when Jim abandons the minstrels, cursing him and exposing his own racism. Thatcher, on the other hand, is disappointed in Jim’s attempts to run away and save his family, having expected him to be grateful for his relative kindness. Jim tells Thatcher he “can’t feed your fantasy that you’re a good, kind master,” because no matter how kind the judge was, he was complicit in Jim’s enslavement. Jim feels more immediate loyalty to the Black men he encounters when he finally reaches Graham farm, where Sadie and Lizzie are being held, demonstrating that similar circumstances more effectively unite people than devotion that is feigned and coerced.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



PENCIL

James’s pencil represents his desire for and struggle to regain agency and self-determination as an enslaved person. Young George steals the pencil from his enslaver at Jim’s request, and the man implores him to “[t]ell the story with your ears. Listen.” Though Jim does not quite understand, he feels Young George’s advice is profound. Later, Jim witnesses Young George being beaten for stealing the pencil, and even later, hears that he was killed for the alleged crime, despite a lack of evidence. The cost of the pencil—Young George’s life—only makes it more precious to James, who feels compelled to write for the young man, whose voice has been silenced. With the pencil, Jim “wrote myself into being,” and renames himself “James.” Here, he reclaims his autonomy through the written word, which is itself a forbidden act for an enslaved person like himself. In his conversation with Easter, Jim senses his ability to write is a “call to duty,” referencing the feeling that he is in a war against enslavers and their supporters. He always keeps his pencil on him, even when he is sold to the enslaver Henderson, finding its presence comforts him. That the ability to affirm his own identity feels like security to Jim—a runaway slave, whose life is constantly endangered—is significant, demonstrating how his sense of self has become linked to his survival. In other words, Jim has begun to view himself not only as a man trying to survive war but as “a man who will not let his story be self-related, but self-written.” Ultimately, the reader realizes they are reading that

very “self-written” tale, evidence that James has succeeded in determining his own legacy.



BOOKS

Books represent the intellectual freedom that cannot be taken away by the institution of slavery. Before the novel begins, Jim has taught himself and other enslaved people to read using the books in Judge Thatcher’s library. While it is worth noting that he obtains this knowledge without his enslaver’s permission, the fact remains that Jim is able to conceal what he has learned by maintaining a façade of ignorance. Maintaining this façade falsely reassures Jim’s white enslavers that he is incompetent, which in turn grants him the freedom to expand his knowledge in secret. After discovering the robbers’ stash of books on their skiff, Jim reflects further on the power of reading: “[Reading] was a completely private affair and completely free and, therefore, completely subversive.” Because no one can tell whether Jim is merely seeing the words or comprehending their meaning, the act of reading falls outside the realm of his enslavers’ control or even perception. Jim’s reading also allows him to engage in discourse with the logic of his own enslavement, as seen when he imagines arguments with Voltaire and John Locke. Reading the works of such writers lets Jim debate them from the position of an equal, a status from which he is barred in the physical world. At the novel’s climax, Judge Thatcher is appalled to discover Jim’s literacy, affirming that the act of reading subverts white expectations of Black intelligence and is a means for enslaved people to reclaim some portion of their stolen liberty.

Related Themes:



Page Number: 9-10

Explanation and Analysis

At the novel’s opening, Jim waits at Miss Watson’s kitchen door for some cornbread. Hearing Huck and Tom hiding in the tall grass, he first calls them “[t]hose little bastards” and then “[t]hose white boys.” The clear negative connotation of “bastards” conveys Jim’s irritation, while describing them as “white” highlights their racial difference from himself. Jim seems to associate Huck and Tom’s whiteness with the way they treat him as “either a villain or prey, but certainly their toy.” By linking the boys’ manipulative behavior with their race, Jim implies that they, like other white people, have demeaned him as a Black man in order to suit their own purposes. That said, he does not seem to view them as a threat, comparing them to “chiggers, mosquitoes, and other biting bugs”—Huck and Tom are primarily an annoyance, and their attempts to make Jim part of some game point to their youthful innocence.

Jim remarks that “[i]t always pays to give white folks what they want,” implying that submitting to the whims of white people usually benefits Black people like himself. In other words, he willingly steps into the role Huck and Tom expect him to play, opening himself up to their trickery by calling out into the yard. By playing along and feigning ignorance of the boys’ presence, Jim prioritizes white desires, knowing that satisfying their expectations of him can only benefit a Black person like himself.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Doubleday edition of *James* published in 2024.

Part 1, Chapter 1 Quotes

Those white boys, Huck and Tom, watched me. They were always playing some kind of pretending game where I was either a villain or prey, but certainly their toy. They hopped about out there with the chiggers, mosquitoes and other biting bugs, but never made any progress toward me. It always pays to give white folks what they want, so I stepped into the yard and called out into the night, “Who dat dere in da dark lak dat?”

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Huck, Miss Watson, Tom Sawyer

“But what are you going to say when she asks you about it?” I asked.

Lizzie cleared her throat. “Miss Watson, dat some cone-bread lak I neva before et.”

“Try ‘dat be,” I said. “That would be the correct incorrect grammar.”

Related Characters: James (Jim), Lizzie (speaker), Sadie, Miss Watson

Related Themes:



Page Number: 14

Explanation and Analysis

Miss Watson’s cornbread tastes terrible, so Sadie tells Lizzie she does not have to eat it. Jim uses this as an opportunity to teach his daughter how to conduct herself in

front of their white enslaver. Obviously, Lizzie cannot tell the truth and insult Miss Watson's cooking, as this will be viewed as impertinence. Instead, Jim coaches her to conceal her honest feelings and to do so in the altered "slave dialect" that Black people adopt around white people. This method of speech is designed to give the impression that Lizzie is of lesser intelligence, thereby satisfying white expectations of Black inferiority. Jim calls this "correct incorrect grammar," highlighting the irony of their situation: they are intelligent enough to know that the best way to pacify their white oppressors is to feign simplemindedness. Here, the novel characterizes white society as ignorant of Black intelligence and shows how supporting this racist perception can actually help enslaved Black people survive their oppressive circumstances.

Part 1, Chapter 2 Quotes

☞ That evening I sat down with Lizzie and six other children in our cabin and gave a language lesson. These were indispensable. Safe movement through the world depended on mastery of language, fluency.

[...]

"White folks expect us to sound a certain way and it can only help if we don't disappoint them," I said. "The only ones who suffer when they are made to feel inferior is us. Perhaps I should say 'when they don't feel superior.'"

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Lizzie

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 21

Explanation and Analysis

Sitting down for a routine language lesson, Lizzie asks her father why she and the other children have to learn what Jim refers to as "slave talk." Jim describes these instructional lessons as "indispensable" because "[s]afe movement through the world" depends on their speech. Here, he is referring specifically to the way Black people speak in the presence of white people, who "expect [Black people] to sound a certain way." In later paragraphs, Jim goes on to describe the basic rules of slave talk, which include avoiding eye contact, not speaking first, and avoiding addressing subjects directly when speaking with another slave. Since the enslaved people's natural speech is much more sophisticated, slave talk can be viewed as a performance of lesser intelligence acted out for the sake of preserving white comfort. To "disappoint" white

expectations is to put oneself in danger of provoking violence in their enslavers, who do not enjoy feeling "inferior" or even questioning their own superiority. Here, the novel examines how Black safety is often dependent on white comfort, necessitating the performance of Black subordination. If white people are not convinced of their superiority, they must reckon with the truth: that they have enslaved their equals. Rather than face this uncomfortable truth, they prefer to live willfully ignorant of Black intelligence. In short, Jim teaches the children how to speak to aid their survival in an oppressive world.

Part 1, Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ "Well, yes, but all men are equal. That's my point. But even you have to admit the presence of, shall we call him—it—the devil, in your African humans." Voltaire adjusted his position and held his hands to the fire.

"You're saying we're equal, but also inferior," I said.

"I'm detecting a disapproving tone," he said. "Listen, my friend. I'm on your side. I'm against the institution of slavery. Slavery of any kind. You know that I am an abolitionist of the first order."

"Thank you?"

"You're welcome."

Related Characters: James (Jim), Voltaire (speaker), Judge Thatcher

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 50

Explanation and Analysis

After he is bitten by a rattlesnake, Jim falls into a fever dream in which he has a conversation with the French philosopher and writer, Voltaire. Jim is familiar with Voltaire's work, having read some of his books in Judge Thatcher's office. The ability to read books frees Jim intellectually, allowing him to debate Voltaire in a way he is unable to do in the physical world, where he must maintain a guise of lesser intelligence.

In the quoted passage, Voltaire exposes his own hypocrisy by declaring "all men are equal," while going on to suggest "the devil" is present in people of African descent. When Jim calls out this dehumanizing contradiction, Voltaire insists he is Jim's ally but refuses to amend his statement about Black inferiority. The question mark after Jim's expression of

appreciation indicates he is being sarcastic, as Voltaire's support is obviously insincere based on his racist comments. That Voltaire seems to mistake Jim's scorn for actual gratitude points to his staunch belief in his own goodness, demonstrating the tendency of white people to deny any truth that makes them uncomfortable—including their own moral failings.

Part 1, Chapter 7 Quotes

☞ Then I wrote my first words. I wanted to be certain that they were mine and not some I had read from a book in the judge's library. I wrote:

I am called Jim. I have yet to choose a name.

[...]

But I will not let this condition define me. I will not let myself, my mind, drown in fear and outrage. I will be outraged as a matter of course. But my interest is in how these marks that I am scratching on this page can mean anything at all. If they can have meaning, then life can have meaning, then I can have meaning.

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Judge Thatcher

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 55

Explanation and Analysis

Alone on Jackson Island, Jim fashions a pen from a stick and uses stolen ink to write his first words. Although this is not the pencil he uses in later chapters, the act of writing still represents Jim's struggle to regain autonomy over his life. This desire for self-determination exhibits itself in Jim's wish that his first written words "were mine and not some I had read from a book." Here, Jim equates writing with agency. It is worth noting that he does not refer to "Jim" as his name, but as the name people call him. As he himself did not choose this name, he rejects it as his identity.

Jim vows not to let the "condition" of enslavement define his life. He even rejects the possibility of being overwhelmed by the emotions his enslavement provokes, namely "fear and outrage." This is not to say that Jim is not angry, only that he wishes to be something other than an angry enslaved person. His individual desires make themselves known in the last few sentences of this passage: "my interest is in how these marks that I am scratching on this page can mean anything at all." Jim is fascinated with the way written

narrative can convey meaning and what meaning he might be able to convey by writing his own story. This moment's significance revolves around Jim's commitment to reclaiming his own agency and his realization that telling his story might change his life.

Part 1, Chapter 11 Quotes

☞ At that moment the power of reading made itself clear and real to me. If I could see the words, then no one could control them or what I got from them. They couldn't even know if I was merely seeing them or reading them, sounding them out or comprehending them. It was a completely private affair and completely free and, therefore, completely subversive.

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Huck

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 73

Explanation and Analysis

Jim wants to read some of the stolen books he and Huck discovered in the robbers' skiff, but he worries that the boy will wake and see him. Then he realizes that Huck has no way of knowing whether he is comprehending the words or just looking at them. This is what Jim refers to as "the power of reading"—the ability to consume information outside the perception and control of his white enslavers. The knowledge that enslaved people are forbidden from reading makes this activity "completely subversive," as Jim is directly refuting white expectations of his own ignorance. While in the presence of white people, he must continue to pretend he is "merely seeing" the words rather than "comprehending them" to maintain the illusion of his inferiority—in turn, this actually enhances his sense that reading is equal to freedom. Not only is Jim free to learn and dissect information, but he is also free from the criticism and punishment that would come with white awareness of his studies. In characterizing reading as a "completely private affair," Jim highlights how literacy empowers him to shape his own intellectual landscape, thereby reclaiming some of his stolen agency.

Part 1, Chapter 15 Quotes

☞ I had already come to understand the tidiness of lies, the lesson learned from the stories told by white people seeking to justify my circumstance. [...] And so, after all these books, the Bible itself was the least interesting of all. I could not enter it, did not want to enter it, and then understood that I recognized it as a tool of my enemy. I chose the word *enemy*, and still do, as oppressor necessarily supposes a victim.

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), John Locke

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 90

Explanation and Analysis

Alone, Jim reads the narrative of Venture Smith, an enslaved man brought from Africa to the United States in the 18th century. Jim casts doubt on the narrative's "so-called self-related" qualities, believing the exhaustive detail and neat themes indicate "the tidiness of lies." In suggesting that Venture Smith's narrative was manipulated by "white people seeking to justify my circumstance"—that circumstance being enslavement—Jim calls attention to the way white people attempt to romanticize the hardships of slavery to make them appear reasonable and palatable. This rationalization allows them to continue oppressing Black people without guilt, willfully ignoring the more violent truths of enslavement.

Jim goes on to describe the Bible as "the least interesting" book in his stash. This religious text seems inaccessible to Jim, who truthfully does "not want to enter it" because of the way it has been used to justify his enslavement. This perspective recalls earlier moments in the novel, when Jim tells how his enslavers promise him a just reward in the Christian heaven for all his suffering. The purpose of such empty promises is to keep him and other enslaved people submissive, which explains why Jim views the Bible as "a tool of my enemy." At the end of this quote, he unpacks his own language, specifically using the word *enemy* because "oppressor necessarily supposes a victim." Jim does not view himself as a victim as much as he thinks of himself as fighting a war against an enemy—white enslavers—alluding to the conviction of his own equality and determination to reclaim agency.

Part 1, Chapter 16 Quotes

☞ *My name is James. I wish I could tell my story with a sense of history as much as industry. I was sold when I was born and then sold again. My mother's mother was from someplace on the continent of Africa, I had been told or perhaps simply assumed. I cannot claim to any knowledge of that world or those people, whether my people were kings or beggars [...] I can tell you that I am a man who is cognizant of his world, a man who has a family, who loves a family, who has been torn from his family, a man who can read and write, a man who will not let his story be self-related, but self-written.*

With my pencil, I wrote myself into being. I wrote myself to here.

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Young George

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 93

Explanation and Analysis

With the pencil stolen by Young George, Jim begins to write a narrative of his life. While these are not the first words he has written, this is the first time he has rechristened himself "James" on paper, asserting his ability to determine his own identity. Jim regrets his lack of family history—having been born into enslavement, his ancestral roots have been erased, another casualty of his oppression. Here, he seems to compare his own narrative to that of Venture Smith, who remembered his journey from Africa to the United States. Unlike Smith, Jim wishes his narrative to be "self-written" instead of "self-related," alluding to the importance of telling his story in his own words rather than through the medium of a white listener. To this end, he describes his most significant attributes as his devotion to his family and his ability to engage intellectually with the world around him. Here, Jim refutes white society's degradation of enslaved Black people, highlighting the characteristics that emphasize his humanity. Telling his own story and writing himself "into being" is an act of resistance against the institution of slavery, which has defined his identity up to this point. Finally, the transition from italics to regular text seems to indicate that the novel itself is part of the narrative Jim has written.

Part 1, Chapter 18 Quotes

“What you’re saying is that if someone pays you enough, it’s okay to abandon what you have claimed to understand as moral and right.”

“When you put it that way,” he said.

“When I put it that way what?”

“They wanted a constitution that would justify their behavior. If I hadn’t written it for them, someone else would have. What in the world would be different if that had happened?”

I looked at him. “You tell me,” I said.

Related Characters: James (Jim), John Locke (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 102-103

Explanation and Analysis

Jim dreams he is speaking with John Locke, the English philosopher whose views on slavery are notoriously hypocritical. Though Locke claimed to be against slavery in general, he helped write the *Fundamental Constitutions of Carolina* (1669), which gave southern planters absolute power over their enslaved Black people. In this passage, Jim accuses Locke of abandoning “what you have claimed to understand as moral and right” in exchange for financial gain. It is worth noting that Jim’s access to Locke’s books allows him to engage the philosopher’s ideas in a way that is unavailable to him in the physical world, underlining how reading is a gateway to intellectual freedom. Locke responds to Jim’s criticism by first implying that his phrasing is unfair and then arguing that “someone else would have” written in defense of slavery even if he had not. Jim takes issue with this argument but wants Locke to name “[w]hat in the world would be different if that had happened.” The answer, of course, is that if Locke had refused to write the constitution, he would not have compromised his own morality. But the truth that Locke has invalidated his own ethics is too uncomfortable for the philosopher to admit—he responds by calling his views “complex,” avoiding the real issue. By confronting Locke in this passage, Jim highlights how even white people who view themselves as Black allies often ignore their own moral failings and disloyalty.

“I could believe it, I thought, pretending, in slave fashion, not to be there. After being cruel, the most notable white attribute was gullibility. As evidenced by Huck’s reaction. He said, “You fellers are amazin.””

Related Characters: James (Jim), Huck (speaker), The Duke, The King

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 106

Explanation and Analysis

Jim and Huck meet the King and the Duke, two grifters who are fleeing the consequences of their most recent lies. Listening to the men discuss their most successful cons, Jim wholeheartedly believes in their ability to trick other white people. Noting that he—in the presence of the King and the Duke—is “pretending, in slave fashion, not to be there” highlights the dehumanizing white expectation that enslaved Black people go unnoticed when they are not being addressed. This corroborates the following statement, in which Jim calls white people in general “cruel” but also gullible. Huck’s response to the King and the Duke’s exaggerated claims seems to prove this claim: “You fellers are amazin.” While Huck’s wide-eyed wonder can be blamed on his youthful innocence, it is significant that Jim attributes such naivety to all white people, even the adults. This recalls other moments in the novel in which Jim’s white enslavers engage in willful ignorance, particularly when it comes to denying his humanity. Jim’s own linguistic performance revolves around maintaining the illusion that he is a lesser being in order to keep white people comfortable with his presence. In this context, white people are characterized as unaware and gullible, while Black people are better able to perceive the world’s uncomfortable and disillusioning truths. In other words, lack of awareness and choice of belief are privileges only enjoyed by the white population, while Black people are forced to face the hard truth of existence daily.

Part 1, Chapter 21 Quotes

☞ “Yes, but them people liked it, Jim. Did you see their faces? They had to know them was lies, but they wanted to believe. What do you make of that?”

“Folks be funny lak dat. Dey takes the lies dey want and throws away the truths dat scares ‘em.”

[...]

“I reckon I do that, too,” the boy said.

“What say?”

“I kin see how much you miss yer family and yet I don’t think about it. I forget that you feel things jest like I feel. I know you love them.”

“Thank you, Huck.”

Related Characters: James (Jim), Huck (speaker), The Duke, The King

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 126-127

Explanation and Analysis

Jim and Huck flee the revival and sail away on their raft, leaving the King and the Duke behind. Huck worries that the townspeople will punish the con men harshly, and Jim reminds him that the men are criminals and liars. In this passage, Huck argues that the townsfolk liked the men’s lies about being Christian missionaries because “they wanted to believe.” Jim responds by highlighting the human tendency to “takes the lies dey want and throws away the truths dat scares ‘em.” This observation applies to other situations throughout the novel, especially the way Jim and other enslaved Black people perform ignorance in order to maintain white comfort. In this context, white people are more than happy to ignore Black people’s humanity in favor of believing them to be lesser beings, thereby justifying their enslavement.

Huck confesses that he, like the people at the revival, prefers to turn a blind eye to unpleasant truths. In particular, he forgets that Jim “feel[s] things jest like I feel,” especially grief over being separated from his family. Though he is a young boy, Huck is able, in this moment, to acknowledge his own willful ignorance and the harm he does by thinking of Jim as anything other than a human being. Jim responds with sincere gratitude for this rare offer of empathy, highlighting how unusual it is for a white person to admit their mistake.

Part 1, Chapter 22 Quotes

☞ The Duke swung his belt and caught me at my knees. It did hurt. He laughed and did it again. I didn’t wince.

“You see that?” the King said. “I say, did you see that? They don’t even feel like no human man.”

[...]

“Don’t tear him up too much,” the King said. “We gotta be able to sell him. We cain’t get a dime fer him if’n he’s torn all asunder.”

“Hell, man,” the Duke said. “He ain’t no proper people. He don’t feel pain like we do. He need a lesson he kin remember. Nextwise, he’ll get it into his head to run again. That’s the way these creatures is built.”

Related Characters: The Duke, The King (speaker), James (Jim), Huck

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 132

Explanation and Analysis

The King and the Duke take Jim and Huck captive, planning to sell Jim repeatedly in order to con people out of their money. Before they enact this plan, the Duke insists on punishing Jim for running away from them in the last town, and he begins to beat him in front of a distraught Huck. In this passage, Jim’s refusal to wince at the Duke’s initial blows suggests he is engaged in another kind of performance, pretending not to be hurt in order to deny the men their depraved satisfaction. The King takes this as proof that Black people “don’t even feel like no human man,” implying that Jim’s high pain tolerance is evidence that he is something other than a human being. Later, King objects to the Duke’s continued beating, but only because “[w]e cain’t get a dime fer him if’n he’s torn all asunder.” Here, the novel examines how concern for Jim’s wellbeing centers on the idea that he is property whose value depreciates with damage. Finally, the Duke justifies his violent treatment of Jim by insisting he “don’t feel pain like we do” and he “need a lesson he kin remember” to prevent him from running off again. Here, stripping enslaved people of their humanity allows enslavers to justify violence as a kind of fear-based training mechanism. That the Duke refers to Jim and other enslaved people as “these creatures” indicates that he views Black people as if they are animals.

Part 1, Chapter 24 Quotes

“Why is that, Jim? I thought we was friends. I thought you trusted me.”

“I does trust you, Huck. Cain’t you see dat? I trusts you wif my life.”

[...]

“I understand why you talk the way you do.”

“What do you mean?” I asked.

“I mean it makes sense.”

I studied his face. He was talking with his eyes closed, as much fighting sleep as losing to it. There was a lot of this in that face.

“You be a smart boy, Huck.”

Related Characters: James (Jim), Huck (speaker), Easter

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 144

Explanation and Analysis

Huck overhears Jim and Easter speaking in their natural voices, without the affected slave dialect. Afterwards, he confronts Jim, believing his performance is an indicator that he does not trust Huck. It is worth noting that Jim insists here that he “trusts [Huck] wif my life,” suggesting he truly cares what the boy thinks of him, implying sincere affection. Again, Huck exhibits an unusual maturity in his ability to self-reflect, saying, after some thought, that the way Jim talks around white people “makes sense.” Even though he doesn’t articulate it, this response implies that Huck understands the purpose behind slave talk: to pacify white expectations by pretending to be less intelligent. It is even possible that Huck understands Jim’s reason for putting up the same façade when talking to him, even if it hurts his feelings. Like his seemingly earnest declaration of trust, Jim’s response to Huck here feels significantly tender: he studies the boy’s face and says “[t]here was a lot of this in that face.” While it is not stated outright, the “this” Jim sees in Huck’s face can be interpreted as his own features, alluding obliquely to the boy’s true parentage. When he compliments Huck’s intelligence and perception, then, it is tinged with hidden pride for his son.

Part 1, Chapter 26 Quotes

“White folks watch us work and forget how long we’re left alone in our heads. Working and waiting.”

I smiled. “If only they knew the danger in that.”

“I don’t believe they even know we talk to each other,” Easter said.

“They can’t accept it. They won’t accept it. And they’re always surprised.”

Related Characters: James (Jim), Easter (speaker), Young George, Mr. Wiley

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 151

Explanation and Analysis

In this conversation, Wiley leaves Easter and James to their tasks, and Easter instructs Jim on how to make horseshoes. As they work, the older man tells Jim about a slave who was killed for stealing a pencil, and Jim knows he is talking about Young George, who gave him the pencil he still has in his pocket. The two men also talk about white ignorance of the interior lives of Black people, who have ample time to think deeply while laboring at repetitive tasks. Jim remarks that such time for thought is dangerous to their enslavers, as it gives enslaved people an opportunity to think for and about themselves and their own situation. Like Jim’s pencil, individual thought is a tool for reclaiming agency and defining oneself apart from the institution of slavery. That white enslavers do not think of Black people as human beings with internal thoughts puts them at a disadvantage, as they never suspect their slaves of harboring revolutionary thoughts.

Additionally, Easter speculates that white people do not “even know we talk to each other.” Jim agrees, saying “[t]hey can’t accept it. They won’t accept it.” Though he only shifts one word between these two sentences, the difference is significant: “can’t” implies white people are unable to accept the idea of Black intercommunication, while “won’t” implies they choose not to accept it. Here again, white people are described as being willfully ignorant of that which makes them uncomfortable. In the context of this conversation, slave talk becomes not only a tool to pacify white expectations, but a way of communicating in a code that only enslaved people can understand.

Part 1, Chapter 30 Quotes

☞ I made eye contact with a couple of people in the crowd and the way they looked at me was different from any contact I had ever had with white people. They were open to me, but what I saw, looking into them, was hardly impressive. They sought to share this moment of mocking me, mocking *darkies*, laughing at the poor slaves, with joyful, spirited clapping and stomping. I looked at one woman who might have been intrigued by me or taken with me, the entertainer. I saw the surface of her, merely the outer shell, and realized that she was mere surface all the way to her core.

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Daniel Decatur Emmett, Polly

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 171

Explanation and Analysis

Jim's first performance with the Virginia Minstrels begins with a march down main street. In this passage, Jim describes the disorienting experience of performing as a Black man disguised as a white man wearing blackface, and the unique access his assumed whiteness gives him to white society. He first notes a difference in perception, saying "the way they looked at [him] was different" from any of his prior experiences with white people. They are "open" to Jim, revealing more of their true natures than they do when they interact with a Black person. Significantly, he finds their inner world is "hardly impressive," as their connection is based on mocking others. Unbeknownst to the crowd, Jim is one of the "poor slaves" they are laughing at, and he finds the joy they take in dehumanizing people like him disturbing.

Singling Polly out, Jim witnesses how his performance seems to intrigue her, but the interest is not reciprocated. As he is constantly performing for white people in some way, Jim himself has cultivated a rich interior life of thought and observation. Polly, in comparison, is "mere surface all the way to her core"—in other words, Jim senses no self-reflection in her. This aligns with the theme characterizing white enslavers as lacking awareness, and it increases Jim's general disillusionment with his oppressors.

☞ Slaves didn't have the luxury of anxiety, but at that moment, I had felt anxiety. Slaves didn't have the luxury of anger toward a white man, but I had felt anger. The anger was a good bad feeling. In addition, my feelings about Daniel Emmett were complicated, confused. He bought me, yes, but reportedly not to own me, though he expected something from me—my voice, he claimed. I wondered what he would do if I tried to leave. In my head I could hear him shouting, "But I paid two hundred dollars for you." A man who refused to own slaves but was not opposed to others owning slaves was still a slaver, to my thinking.

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Daniel Decatur Emmett, Polly's Father

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 176

Explanation and Analysis

After Jim's first show with the Virginia Minstrels, Polly's father touches his hair, assuming it is a wig. Walking back to camp, Jim reflects on that moment and his current situation. That Jim describes his feelings of anxiety and anger as luxuries underlines the necessity of suppressing emotions in order to survive. Indulging in these feelings now is liberating—Jim describes his anger at Polly's father as a "good bad feeling." Jim's journey seems to be transforming his sense of self, allowing him to feel emotions he has buried out of necessity, which in turn signifies an increase in both confidence and agency.

Jim is confused by Daniel Decatur Emmett, who professes to be opposed to slavery but still holds Jim's bill of sale. Emmett's claim that Jim has been hired instead of purchased understandably elicits skepticism, as all of Jim's previous encounters with white men have revolved around his condition of enslavement. It is clear to Jim that Emmett "expected something of me," and he predicts the musician will be unhappy if he tries to leave the troupe. This suspicion is rooted in the 200 dollars Emmett paid to "hire" Jim as a tenor, which legally makes Jim Emmett's property, regardless of the man's personal ideals. On that subject, too, Jim is cynical, thinking that Emmett's refusal to own slaves cannot be the sign of a strong moral opposition if he accepts that other men own slaves. Here, the novel examines another mode of white hypocrisy, one that claims benevolence toward Black people while doing nothing to actually prevent their harm.

Part 2, Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ “We’re slaves. We’re not anywhere. Free person, he can be where he wants to be. The only place we can ever be is in slavery.” She looked at Norman. “Are you really a slave?” she asked.

“I am.”

“And you’re colored,” she said.

Norman nodded.

“Who can tell?”

“Nobody,” Norman said.

“Then why do you stay colored?”

“Because of my mother. Because of my wife. Because I don’t want to be white. I don’t want to be one of them.”

Related Characters: Norman, Sammy (speaker), James (Jim), Henderson, Norman’s Wife

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 219

Explanation and Analysis

Jim, Sammy, and Norman pause for a rest while running away from Henderson. Jim remarks that where they run makes no difference, as they are enslaved whether they are in a free or slave state. In this passage, Sammy expands on Jim’s comment, describing enslavement as “[t]he only place we can ever be.” This suggests that enslavement is built so deeply into their identity that it is unescapable, casting understandable doubt on their prospects for gaining anything like freedom.

Sammy questions why Norman chooses to identify as a Black man when he can simply pass as a white man and have an easier life. Norman’s reasoning cites his relationships with his mother and his wife, indicating that his identity is bound up in feelings of loyalty for his family. Unwilling to abandon them to the consequences of their Blackness, he must retain his own racial identity. Furthermore, Norman doesn’t “want to be one of them”—referring to his white enslavers. Having experienced the dehumanization of enslavement, Norman finds the idea of aligning himself with white society repugnant. Like Jim, he views white people as his enemy, despite their physical resemblance to himself. In Norman, the novel investigates how a self-determined identity is sturdier than one that is assigned.

Part 2, Chapter 8 Quotes

☞ *Massa Corey bring me cone bread,
Hoo Ya Hoo Ya!*

*Massa Corey bring me cone bread,
He makes da boat go.*

I opened an eye and watched him awhile, then shut it again because I did not like the sight. Unfortunately, neither I nor the engine’s roar could block out the sound of his dreadful singing. [...]

I imagined Norman upstairs, nervous, but perhaps physically comfortable, not hot and covered with soot, but no doubt more frightened than I was, more lost. I wondered if he was angry. I wondered if I had ever not been angry.

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Norman, Daniel Decatur Emmett, Brock

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 241

Explanation and Analysis

Jim stays in the engine room with Brock while Norman investigates the riverboat’s upper decks. This passage begins while Brock is shoveling coal into the boiler, singing a song about “Massa Corey” in slave talk. The lyrics are reminiscent of Emmett’s, which made frequent use of racist stereotypes. Despite the fact that no white people are nearby, Brock always speaks in the affected slave dialect. This makes Jim uncomfortable because it suggests that Brock has fully accepted his enslavement as his identity. Equally discomfiting is the fact that Brock seems to enjoy being enslaved, even confined to the engine room at all hours. This, combined with Brock’s devotion to his absent master, make Jim distrust the other man despite his Blackness.

His thoughts turning to Norman, Jim contemplates the differences in their situations. He speculates that Norman is more “physically comfortable” than himself, but “no doubt more frightened” because he is performing whiteness, which always carries the potential danger of discovery. In the last sentences of this quote, Jim seems to seek connection with Norman by imagining their shared anger. His own anger—at the world that condones his enslavement—seems omnipresent and eternal. This is not the first time Jim’s anger has caught his attention, and its repeated appearance suggests he is becoming more aware of how his own disillusionment and rage can be a tool wielded for his liberation.

Part 3, Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ “Why me, Jim?”

Maybe because I was tired of the slave voice. Maybe because I hated myself for having lost my friend. Maybe because the lie was burning through me. Because of all of those reasons, I said, “Because, Huck, and I hope you hear this without thinking I’m crazy or joking, you are my son.”

Huck shot out a short laugh. “What?”

“You are my son. And I am your father.”

“Why are you talking like that?”

“Are you referring to my diction or my content?”

“What? What’s content?”

Related Characters: James (Jim), Huck (speaker), Norman, Huck’s Mom

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 253

Explanation and Analysis

Huck asks Jim why he chose to save him instead of Norman, who likely drowned in the river after the boat exploded. In this passage, Jim is too tired of his various performances to keep up the act. Not only does he drop the “slave voice,” he reveals the lie he has hidden from Huck and even the reader up to this point: he is Huck’s biological father. This moment is significant, indicating that Jim is completely fed up with pretending to be someone he is not. His performance, which was meant to protect him, has failed to keep him, his family, and his friends safe. It has become unsustainable.

Huck’s reaction to the truth is one of shock and confusion. By telling him this secret, Jim has taken away some of Huck’s remaining innocence, opening his eyes to unpleasant realities. The fact that he is finally speaking to Huck in his normal voice amplifies the sense that Jim and his son can now see one another clearly—as family. It is worth noting that Huck—like Judge Thatcher in a later chapter—seems more preoccupied with Jim’s shifting speech than with the “content” of that speech. This suggests that being confronted with particularly distressing facts causes people to fixate on minutiae in an effort to delay the moment of full realization.

☞ “Belief has nothing to do with truth. Believe what you like.

Believe I’m lying and move through the world as a white boy. Believe I’m telling the truth and move through the world as a white boy anyway. Either way, no difference.” I looked at the boy’s face and I could see that he had feelings for me and that was the root of his anger. He had always felt affection for me, if not actual love. He had always looked to me for protection, even when he thought he was trying to protect me.

“Liar,” he cried.

I took it.

Related Characters: James (Jim), Huck (speaker)

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 257

Explanation and Analysis

Huck struggles to accept the truth that Jim is his father, and he wrestles with what this means for his identity. The boy looks to Jim for guidance during this process, but Jim resolutely leaves the decision about what to do next to Huck, which frustrates him. In this passage, Jim responds to Huck accusing him of being a liar and asking why he should trust anything Jim says. In denying any connection between belief and truth, Jim recalls all the instances in which people—particularly white people—have engaged in willful ignorance. For example, white denial of Black intelligence is the reason slave talk exists, as it’s a way to maintain the illusion that enslaved people are inferior. Jim extends this logic to Huck’s situation, freeing him to believe whatever he likes but to “move through the world as a white boy” regardless.

Here, Jim exhibits fatherly concern for Huck, encouraging him to continue passing as white because he knows his life will be easier than if he identifies as Black. Huck’s own affection for Jim amplifies his anger at having been lied to, as does the sense that Jim does not want him around (when really, Jim is trying to protect him from the consequences of accompanying a runaway). In these shifting dynamics between Jim and Huck, the novel examines the complex intersection of race, identity, and loyalty, and how they can work together to strengthen or dissolve a relationship. Huck’s outburst at the end indicates that there are consequences to concealing the truth that are not protective but, rather, potentially devastating.

Part 3, Chapter 3 Quotes

“Imagine it all as a state of war,” Locke said. “You have been conquered, and so long as the war continues, you shall be a slave.”

“When does the war end?” I asked.

“Does it end? That’s the question. Who gets to say that it’s over? A war continues until the victor says it’s over.”

“If I am in a war, then I have the right to fight back. That follows, doesn’t it? I have a right, perhaps a duty, to kill my enemy.”

“Well, now.”

Related Characters: James (Jim), John Locke (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 263

Explanation and Analysis

While wrestling with a gigantic catfish, Jim is pulled underwater, where he hallucinates the English philosopher John Locke once more. When Jim asks if he has come to continue defending slavery, Locke directs him to imagine his enslavement as “state of war.” In this analogy, enslaved people “have been conquered,” and will remain so as long as the war rages on. Using this logic, Locke attempts to make the institution of slavery a more natural state of affairs, describing it as the reasonable result of a war between white people and Black people. The assertion that war only ends when “the victor says it’s over” implies that enslavement will continue until white people tire of it. Using this example, Locke once again turns the real-life suffering caused by slavery into an abstract thought experiment involving concepts rather than people.

When Jim endeavors to challenge Locke on the playing field of his own analogy, the philosopher seems taken aback. Jim asserts that, if he is truly embroiled in a war, he has “the right to fight back.” In other words, Jim and other enslaved people have a right to resist their enslavement in any way they can. For Jim, this resistance has taken many forms: he has run away from his enslavers, taught himself to read, and is slowly reclaiming his agency by writing a narrative of his life. It is when Jim claims he has “a right, perhaps a duty, to kill my enemy” that Locke becomes openly uncomfortable, replying only, “Well, now.” This noncommittal response seems to confirm that Jim’s logic is sound, but that Locke is unhappy with the conclusion he has drawn. In this way, he once again contradicts himself, only committing to

arguments that benefit his point of view. For his part, Jim’s assertion that he has a right to kill his enemy points to his understandable disillusionment with any kind of peaceful road to freedom.

“Huck showed the excitement of a boy at the sight of our catch. I was reminded that he was just that, a boy. He could have gone through life without the knowledge I had given him and he would have been no worse off for it. But I understood at that moment that I had shared the truth with him for myself. I needed for him to have a choice.”

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Huck

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 264

Explanation and Analysis

Huck helps Jim wrangle the enormous catfish with great satisfaction. In this passage, Jim notes his son’s childlike excitement and is “reminded that he was just that, a boy.” It is worth noting that Huck’s apparent whiteness afforded him a higher social status than Jim for most of the novel, and even now that the truth of his parentage has been revealed, Jim can still forget he is just a child. Considering Huck’s youth, Jim reflects that he did not need to tell him the truth, especially since it has thrown his identity and their relationship into confusion. Applying these ideas to a larger scale, white society can continue to go through life ignorant to the uncomfortable truth of Black humanity and, like Huck, they would be “no worse off” for their lack of awareness. Here, the novel examines the comfort brought about by innocence, which is lost when a person becomes aware of harsh realities.

After considering these things, Jim concludes that he “shared the truth with [Huck] for myself,” saying he needed “for him to have a choice.” The first part of this epiphany implies that Jim told Huck the truth for self-interested reasons, perhaps wanting Huck to know him as a father rather than a friend. The second part changes things slightly: familiar with his own need for autonomy, Jim tells Huck the truth to give him a choice. Whether this choice is between living as a white boy or a biracial boy, joining Jim on the run or staying in Missouri, it is clear that Jim did not think Huck could understand his own capacity for self-determination without full knowledge of his racial identity.

Part 3, Chapter 8 Quotes

☛ I had exacted revenge. But for whom? For one act, or many? Against one man, many men or the world? I wondered if I should feel guilty. Should I have felt some pride in my action? Had I done a brave thing? Had I done an evil thing? Was it evil to kill evil? The truth was that I didn't care. It was this apathy that left me wondering about myself—not wondering why I didn't feel anything or whether I was incapable of feeling, but wondering what else I was capable of doing. It was not an altogether bad feeling.

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Katie, Hopkins

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 284

Explanation and Analysis

Alone on Jackson Island, Jim reckons with his thoughts and feelings after murdering the overseer Hopkins, who raped Katie. In his attempt to comprehend his own actions, Jim investigates how his identity has changed in the aftermath of such a violent event. In this passage, he first conceptualizes the murder as “revenge” but cannot determine the specific details. He puzzles over who he meant to avenge—Katie or himself? Neither can he decide which of the overseer's numerous sins he intended to punish, or if Hopkins' murder was an act against white men as a collective. His emotions seem flattened—he feels neither guilt, nor pride, nor bravery. Alone with himself, Jim debates the correctness of his actions as he once debated Locke and Voltaire. In the end, Jim concludes that he does not care about the moral rightness or wrongness of his actions as much as what his lack of feeling implies for further action. Jim's suffering has stripped him of hope, leaving him cold and disillusioned with the world. Rather than being disturbed by this newfound apathy, Jim seems to experience a kind of freedom—no longer concerned with the abstract philosophical concepts of right and wrong, he wonders “what else I was capable of doing.” Like the anger he felt in previous chapters, this numbness “was not an altogether bad feeling,” as it gives him liberty to take further swift action against injustice.

Part 3, Chapter 9 Quotes

☛ “Why on earth would you think that I can't imagine the trouble I'm in? After you've tortured me and eviscerated me and emasculated me and left me to burn slowly to death, is there something else you'll do to me? Tell me, Judge Thatcher, what is there that I can't imagine?”

[...]

“Are you going to kill me?”

“The thought crossed my mind. I haven't decided. Oh, sorry, let me translate that for you. I ain't 'cided, Massa.”

I had never seen a white man filled with such fear. The remarkable truth, however, was that it was not the pistol, but my language, the fact that I didn't conform to his expectations, that I could read, that had so disturbed and frightened him.

Related Characters: James (Jim), Judge Thatcher (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 290

Explanation and Analysis

Jim confronts Judge Thatcher in his library, dropping his performed slave talk and speaking to the judge as an equal. Thatcher declares that Jim is in more trouble than he can imagine, provoking the speech which begins this passage. Here, Jim eloquently challenges the judge's assumption that he cannot imagine the trouble he is in, as a runaway slave, after spending a lifetime watching Black people like him be violently punished for far less. By demonstrating to Thatcher that he understands perfectly what heinous acts he and other white people are capable of, Jim shames the judge by illuminating his most despicable acts.

Jim's shifting language amplifies Thatcher's shame and fear. After pretending ignorance for so long, Jim's extreme level of awareness comes as a shock. Not only does his language reveal Jim's identity—he is a human being, abused by other human beings—it forces Thatcher to reckon with the truth: that his worst behavior has been perceived by equals. Jim's speech clashes with the judge's expectations of Black inferiority, shaking the philosophical foundations that have justified his treatment of enslaved people for so long. The fear that fills Thatcher, then, is not fear of what Jim will do to him, but fear of what Jim's intelligence implies—that he himself is morally depraved.

Part 3, Chapter 11 Quotes

☞ “I am the angel of death, come to offer sweet justice in the night,” I said. “I am a sign. I am your future. I am James.” I pulled back the hammer on my pistol.

Related Characters: James (Jim) (speaker), Sadie, Lizzie

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 302

Explanation and Analysis

Having set fire to the cornfield at the farm where Sadie and Lizzie are being held, James and the other enslaved men direct the women and children to run. James confronts an elderly white man, presumably one of the enslavers, who is demanding the enslaved people help him put out the fire, referring to them with racial slurs. In this passage, James

declares his new, chosen identity as “the angel of death, come to offer sweet justice in the night.” His words are poetic, showing how fully he has abandoned the pretense of slave talk, which led him to deny his true self. That James is the “angel of death” offering “sweet justice” implies that he intends to right the wrongs of enslavement by killing its participants, like the man standing before him. James goes on to call himself “a sign” and “your future,” perhaps suggesting that he views the rebellion he has incited to be the first of many uprisings. Lastly, introducing himself as James to a white man he intends to kill shows how thoroughly James has committed to writing his own narrative. Having sacrificed so much to recover his agency, James now prioritizes his sense of self over the comfort of others, leaning wholeheartedly into his new self-proclaimed identity.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

THE NOTEBOOK OF DANIEL DECATUR EMMETT

The novel opens with a selection of songs from the notebook of Daniel Decatur Emmett, a composer who founded the first troupe of blackface minstrel performers in the 1840s. These songs are written in what Emmett perceived as Black or slave dialect, utilizing poor grammar and simplistic themes. The lyrics romanticize the existence of enslaved people in the American south, making their lives seem simple and idyllic, disregarding the violent reality.

The inclusion of Emmett's lyrics foregrounds ideas about Black language and white perceptions of Black stereotypes. While Emmett's role in the plot has not yet been revealed, his performance of Black life implied by these songs demonstrates how enslaved Black people have no control over their own narratives. At best, these songs portray white ignorance of the plight of enslaved Black people, and at worst, they mock their suffering.



PART 1, CHAPTER 1

Jim—an enslaved Black man living in Missouri in the 1860s—listens as Tom Sawyer and Huckleberry Finn spy on him from the tall grass. Jim is waiting for his enslaver, Miss Watson, to bring him some corn bread from the kitchen. Knowing the boys love games, Jim speculates loudly about hearing a witch sneaking around the dark. He intentionally uses diction meant to make him seem less intelligent than he is, and he pretends to fall asleep. Tom suggests tying Jim up, but Huck is worried about getting in trouble. Tom steals a few of Miss Watson's candles, leaving a nickel so she will not suspect Jim. He moves Jim's hat as a joke, hoping the man will think a witch took it.

As an enslaved Black man, Jim has learned that fulfilling white expectations can only benefit him. Jim's performance for Tom and Huck is self-deprecating and designed to entertain the boys. Incidentally, the act also conceals his own intelligence, making it easier for white people to dehumanize him. Huck's concern that Jim will be blamed for the theft contrasts sharply with Tom's flippant attitude and racist comments, characterizing him as empathetic. Tom's prank shows that he considers Jim to be of lesser intelligence and views him as a source of amusement.



Tom and Huck run away as Miss Watson appears with the corn bread. She asks Jim if he or anyone else was in the kitchen, and he denies seeing anyone. Miss Watson also asks Jim if he has been in Judge Thatcher's library. He laughs, wondering what she thinks he could do with a **book**. Jim returns home to find his wife, Sadie, and daughter, Lizzie waiting for him. The corn bread tastes terrible. Sadie tells Lizzie she doesn't have to eat it, but Jim coaches his daughter on how to respond when Miss Watson asks how she liked it. He instructs her to use "correct incorrect grammar"—to preserve the illusion of her lesser intelligence.

Miss Watson's attitude toward Jim is generally suspicious, suggesting she does not trust him. Jim endeavors to put her at ease by feigning simplicity, joking that he would not know what to do with a book. At home, he teaches Lizzie to prioritize white comfort over honesty, as keeping their enslavers happy is necessary for their own survival. The idea of "correct incorrect grammar" highlights how enslaved Black people perform ignorance in order to pacify white expectations and survive.



Jim joins the other enslaved men—Albert, Old Luke, and Doris—sitting around a fire. They discuss news of runaways from other farms and ask Jim for a story. He begins telling them about a dream that he was in New Orleans, but he shifts when Albert signals that white people are nearby. Hearing Tom and Huck again, Jim tells the men about how a witch moved his hat, switching to stereotypical slave dialect. He and the other men perform the rest of their conversation for the boys, who believe they're hidden. Jim describes meeting a demon rooster in his dream, who told him he was a free man. He pretends to hear more witches in the bushes, scaring Huck and Tom away.

The next morning, Jim is fixing Miss Watson's loose step when Huck appears. Jim asks after Tom Sawyer, who Huck claims was out late "robbin' banks and trains and such." Jim can sense Huck's irritation with his friend, as Tom always has to be the boss during their adventures. Huck asks where Jim learned so many skills, and Jim replies, "Necessity," before amending his response to "'Cessity." Unlike Jim, Huck does not need to worry about being beaten or sold if he does not do what he's told. Huck thinks Miss Watson is crazy because she is always urging him to pray, which he finds ridiculous because he never gets anything he prays for.

Huck tells Jim that Tom made him and some other boys take a blood oath not to reveal gang secrets, but they used spit instead of blood. Jim remarks that Huck is telling their secrets right now, but the boy insists Jim is different, calling him a friend. Jim assures Huck that he can keep a secret. Miss Watson appears and chastises Huck for not making his bed. When the boy is gone, she tells Jim that Huck's father is back in town, and she asks him to keep an eye on Huck. While Tom Sawyer is no real danger to Huck, his father is an abusive alcoholic. Jim does not know why Miss Watson is telling him all this.

PART 1, CHAPTER 2

In the evening, Jim gathers Lizzie and some other children for a language lesson. They learn how to speak the way white people expect enslaved people to, because disappointing white people only leads to suffering. They are not to make eye contact or speak first and must always "let the whites be the ones who name the trouble." Jim runs the children through hypothetical scenarios, instructing them to never suggest that a white person has made a mistake. Mumbling is allowed because white people love to correct slaves. Though Jim does not believe in "their white God," he encourages them to talk about religion, knowing that the better white folks feel, the safer they are.

The men's gathering exhibits the importance of community in oppressive environments. Their exchange of stories shows that they are fully aware of their plight, contradicting the white perception of Black passivity. Again, Jim performs for Tom and Huck, switching dialects to preserve the illusion of his own simplicity. That the enslaved men know they are being perceived contrasts with the boys' lack of awareness, characterizing them and white society in general as naïve and unwilling to acknowledge the truth.



Despite their significant differences, Jim empathizes with Huck's irritation with Tom Sawyer, who always centers himself in their games. Jim's self-editing shows he is constantly performing in the presence of white people, altering his vocabulary to fit their expectations of him. Huck's conversation indicates an unusual fondness for Jim and exhibits how—to some extent—the boy is untouched by the racism of the larger world.



While Jim assumes Huck shares his secrets with him because he is enslaved and therefore not actually "human," Huck surprises him by calling him a friend, emphasizing his youthful innocence. Miss Watson's fear for Huck's safety, while warranted, confuses Jim, who is powerless to stop his own suffering let alone protect others. In this moment, it almost seems like Miss Watson recognizes Jim as a capable human being, but only when it is convenient for her.



Jim's language lesson highlights how his performed dialect is an inherited survival technique designed to pacify white people. "Slave talk" effectively allows white enslavers to maintain an illusion of superiority. It is worth noting that, while Lizzie and the other enslaved children are aware of their performances, the white adults in charge of them are not. This lack of awareness indicates a widespread naivety among white people in this society and shows how Black safety hinges on the maintenance of white comfort, even when the safety they perceive is an illusion.



Huck approaches Jim at work and asks if he prays. Jim assures the boy that he prays often, but can tell Huck is still conflicted about the idea of God. He advises Huck to pray so Miss Watson can hear him, as that will make his life easier. The boy leaves, and Old Luke arrives with news of a free Black man who cut some policemen to avoid being hanged. Luke and Jim notice a white man watching them and switch to slave diction. The man asks if a nearby horse is for sale before moving on. Old Luke says white people love to buy things they don't need.

Knowing that Jim does not believe in God adds layers of nuance to his conversation with Huck. At first, Jim performs piety like he does for other white people. But then he seems to let Huck in on his secret, instructing him to meet Miss Watson's expectations in order to make Huck's life easier (which is exactly what Jim and the other enslaved people do). Jim's conversation with Old Luke suggests that enslaved people are well aware of the dangers they face as Black people in white society, even if they are free. Old Luke's comment alludes to the white desire to possess things for the sake of possessing them, which might be referencing the institution of slavery in general.



Old Luke tells Jim that the man who attacked the police officers was burned alive. No one was indicted for the man's murder because it was an act of a multitude, which Luke interprets as: "If enough of them kill you, they're innocent." Jim wonders if they'll ever get to St. Louis or New Orleans, and Luke responds in slave talk, which makes Jim laugh. A white man, disturbed by their happiness, asks what they're laughing about. Jim and Luke perform ignorance, asking the man if whiskey really runs down the streets of New Orleans. When the man leaves, Jim suggests he is off to get drunk, simply because the man knows that they—enslaved people—cannot. Luke finds this ironic.

Old Luke and Jim's continued conversation demonstrates the futility of seeking justice in a world in which so many people accept the crimes of slavery and murder. It also highlights how white society at large dehumanizes Black people and sees no issue with acquitting itself of any wrongdoing when a Black person dies. Old Luke and Jim are able to find comfort in their shared suffering, but even that small consolation is policed by the white man who interrogates their laughter. Jim's speculation that white people take joy in experiences that exclude Black people—like drinking—paints them as morally depraved.



PART 1, CHAPTER 3

After a surprise snow, Jim chops wood for Miss Watson, hiding some logs to help the older slaves keep warm. He runs into Huck again, who says he has sold all his worldly possessions to Judge Thatcher for a dollar. The boy observes that Jim's complexion is not much darker than his, but Jim explains that his mother was enslaved, so he is, too. Huck has seen some of his father's boot prints in the snow. Jim assures him that he will be all right, but to stay away from the river. Old Luke tells Jim he shouldn't worry about Huck since he's a white boy. Jim laments that he cannot help Huck, even if he wants to.

The fact that Jim has to steal logs for his fellow enslaved people is proof that Miss Watson—and other white enslavers—does not see Black people as human beings with the same physical needs as her. Huck's decision to sell his possessions hints at his future plans. Jim's remarks suggest that familial lineage plays a greater role in determining one's identity than the shade of one's skin. As a white boy, Huck is not enslaved, but his identity is complicated by his relationship with his violent father. Jim's sympathy cannot do much for Huck, illustrating his relative powerlessness in society.



PART 1, CHAPTER 4

Cold weather continues, and Jim hides more logs, though he worries the theft will be noticed. One day, Sadie overhears Miss Watson telling Judge Thatcher that she is going to sell Jim to a man in New Orleans, splitting up their family. Jim immediately packs a bag, intending to run away and hide out on Jackson Island on the river. Sadie protests, implying that he will be killed if discovered. Jim reassures her and Lizzie that he will come back for them, and sets out calmly into the woods, feeling scared and angry.

It is worth noting that, despite Jim's speculation that he will be caught stealing logs, Miss Watson gives no reason for her decision to sell him. Despite Jim's efforts to meet her expectations, Miss Watson chooses to tear his family apart seemingly on a whim, once again illustrating her dehumanization of Black people. Sadie's fear that Jim will be killed if he runs clarifies the high stakes of Black disobedience. That Jim is willing to risk death to stay with his family demonstrates his fierce love and loyalty for them.



At dusk, Jim sails out on a log on the river. He gets stuck in a trotline but manages to break the tether, taking three catfish for his dinner. He makes it to Jackson Island, where he guts the fish and sleeps. The next morning, Jim discovers Huck on the island, covered in blood. Afraid of his violent father, the boy has faked his own death by killing a pig in Pap's cabin. Jim realizes that people will assume he killed Huck, since he ran away at the same time of the supposed murder. This complicates his plan to hide on the island, which might be searched. Huck cannot understand why Miss Watson would sell Jim when he has a family.

While Jim runs away for the sake of maintaining contact with his family, Pap abuses the only family he has, to the point that his son is driven away. Nevertheless, Jim knows that he will likely be blamed for Huck's death, simply because he is Black and ran away at the same time Huck disappeared. Though the injustice of this situation is obvious, it is fairly typical for the society in which Jim and Huck live. Huck's confusion about Miss Watson's plan to sell Jim highlights his childlike innocence; furthermore, his ability to empathize with Jim shows that he has not been fully corrupted by racist white society at this point.



Jim uses a piece of glass to start a fire to cook the fish. Huck is still confused about Miss Watson's desire to sell Jim, as he himself does not value money. Judge Thatcher and some others float by on a ferryboat, firing a small cannon into the water, clearly hoping to find Huck's body. Huck remarks that it would be funny if another body floated up instead, and Jim says, "Hilarious," slipping into his natural speech. He redirects Huck's attention to the boat but is alarmed by his mistake. Jim is afraid of the consequences of Huck's presence, and he hopes the two of them can avoid becoming the corpses everyone is looking for.

Huck's disregard for money points to his childish ignorance of the larger world. Jim, on the other hand, is painfully aware of the severe consequences of their predicament, and his anxiety casts a shadow over Huck's attempt at humor. Jim's unease causes a momentary lapse in his slave dialect, and this slip further erodes his already precarious sense of safety.



PART 1, CHAPTER 5

Jim and Huck camp out in a cave on the island, living on catfish and berries. Huck ponders why his father hates him, remarking that Pap hates the way his hairline has a widow's peak. He notes that Jim has one too. The two of them discuss superstitions, but Jim is only performing interest, worried about Sadie and Lizzie. He tells Huck it will rain tomorrow—he can tell because of the hawks' and the ants' behavior. Jim says all parts of nature talk to one another, but humans have forgotten how to listen. Huck falls asleep.

Huck's preoccupation with Pap Finn's hatred of him shows that—though largely naïve—he has experienced his share of suffering. The mention of Huck and Jim's shared widow's peak hints at some information the novel has yet to reveal. In addition to his speech, Jim is used to performing interest in white conversation—in this respect, Huck is like any other white person who forgets that Jim has worries of his own.



A torrential storm hits, and the island begins to flood. An entire house comes floating down the river and gets stuck against some trees. Huck and Jim climb through a window, seeking provisions. Inside, Jim finds a dead white man. He stops Huck from seeing the corpse, slipping again into his normal speech. While Huck isn't looking, Jim steals some paper and ink from a shelf. He disregards Huck's questions about why he "sounded so funny," and the two watch as the house tears away from the trees and floats off down the river. Jim claims he did not recognize the dead man.

Back in the cave, Jim and Huck chew some bacon that Huck found in the house. Huck wonders who the dead man was, but Jim tells him not to dwell on it. Looking at the young boy, Jim thinks of Lizzie and hates the idea of her being afraid. Reflecting on the irony of their situation, Jim points out that white people will assume he murdered Huck, despite his lack of motive. Huck does not like white people, despite being one. Suddenly, a rattlesnake bites Jim's hand. He sucks out the poison and binds the wound, not sure if he will survive the night.

PART 1, CHAPTER 6

Jim falls into fever dreams from the snake bite. He sees Sadie and Lizzie, and Judge Thatcher's library, where he has spent many hours secretly learning to **read**. Jim wonders what white people would do to someone like him, who has taught other slaves to read. He hallucinates the French writer Voltaire sitting by the fire. Voltaire claims that all men are equal, but undercuts that statement by asserting that Europeans have achieved the "more perfect human form." Jim debates Voltaire, drawing attention to the ways he contradicts himself. Jim hates Voltaire for the way he treats slavery as a philosophical concept rather than a cruel reality. Voltaire attempts to steal Jim's ideas.

Huck wakes Jim, who is feeling less feverish. The boy tells Jim he talks funny in his sleep, and asks him what "hierarchy" means. Jim plays his sleep-talking off as possession, since snakes are associated with the devil. Huck goes out in search of berries, leaving Jim alone, wracked with more chills. Jim is afraid to sleep again, worried he will slip out of slave speech where Huck can hear him. He is frustrated by the imagined debate with Voltaire and ponders how his supposed "equals" must make the case for his equality, as if he cannot do it himself. Huck returns with blackberries and tends to the fire.

The dead white man's presence immediately provokes fear in Jim, suggesting it is typical to blame white death on Black people. The way he shields Huck from seeing the body draws attention to the boy's youth and Jim's desire to preserve his innocence. Jim's performed disguise is beginning to slip in front of Huck, indicating his heightened stress levels are making the ruse unsustainable.



Jim's insistence that Huck forget about the dead man suggests he is concealing something from the boy. His preoccupation with thoughts of Lizzie humanize Jim, reminding the reader of the high stakes of his running away. That Jim has to explain to Huck that he will be blamed for the boy's disappearance highlights Huck's lack of worldly experience. Despite this naivety, Huck wrestles with his identity as a white person and his disapproval for white actions.



Jim's hidden literacy is another aspect of his performance for white people, who would be disturbed if they knew he could read, as it exposes his intelligence and, therefore, his humanity. Reading has given Jim some freedom from his enslavement, as he can engage with the philosophical ideas of typically unapproachable white men, like Voltaire. Jim's frustration with Voltaire stems from the writer's hypocritical assertions about equality and the aloofness with which he discusses slavery, emphasizing that it does not personally affect his reality. That the famous philosopher attempts to copy Jim's words down on paper indicates Jim's low opinion of the man.



Jim's shifting speech patterns draw attention to how frustrating it is for him to keep such a large part of himself—his significant intelligence—a secret in order to make his oppressors comfortable. Thinking again of Voltaire, Jim seems to wish he could argue the case for his equality himself, since he would surely do a better job. The fact that he is unable to display his intellect is evidence alone that white society at large denies him human equality.



PART 1, CHAPTER 7

Jim's condition improves after a few days, and he and Huck catch a rabbit. Worried about Sadie and Lizzie, Jim asks Huck to return to town and check on them, disguised as a girl using clothes they took from the floating house. Huck agrees and paddles his canoe back to the mainland. Alone, Jim fashions a **pen** from a stick and writes his first words using the paper and ink he took from the house. He writes that he is called Jim but has yet to choose a name for himself. He refuses to let his enslavement define him, determined to embrace his own life's meaning by writing it himself.

Jim's concern for his family reminds the reader that the stakes of running away are higher for him than they are for Huck, who will not be killed if he is found and who has no family to bear punishment in his place. Jim is eager to experiment with writing for the first time, showing that he views the act as a way to reclaim some of his stolen agency. His first words reject the idea that his enslaved status defines his identity, and they illustrate a deep longing for self-determination.



PART 1, CHAPTER 8

Jim watches Huck reach the mainland, hoping that if the boy is discovered, his return will take some of the pressure off of Jim himself. The snake bite is healing, and Jim's energy returns. He wonders whether he should tell Huck that the dead man in the floating house was his Pap, but he worries how the boy's reaction will affect the likelihood of his own capture. After three days of being gone, Huck returns, saying some other men are on the island, possibly following him. Not wanting to risk discovery, Jim and Huck retrieve the canoe and sail away from the island.

Huck's running away complicates Jim's situation, but Huck is naively unaware of the risk his presence poses to Jim. While Jim's concealment of the dead man's identity may have originally been motivated by pity for Huck, now he worries that the discovery of his lie will result in Huck betraying him. Despite Jim's apparent affection for Huck, he is not certain the boy is trustworthy, and so he must continue to perform ignorance for him as he would do for other white people.



PART 1, CHAPTER 9

Huck reports to Jim what he observed while in town. One woman told him that everyone was looking for "Huck's murderer," having first assumed it was Pap before he ran out of town once again. Some people think Jim is to blame. Both men have a bounty on their heads. Huck suspects the woman saw through his disguise. He only saw Sadie and Lizzie from a distance, and he tells Jim they both looked sad. Jim promises himself that he will come back for his family.

That townsfolk assume Pap murdered Huck underscores how little familial affection the boy has experienced. Though it is not surprising to hear that Jim is also suspected, confirmation of this detail emphasizes how his identity as a Black man is a liability when it comes to how white people perceive him. Jim's care for his family is juxtaposed with Huck's desire to escape the influence of his own, calling attention to their differences.



Jim and Huck reach shore and hide in the woods during the day. They plan to travel along the river at night, fashioning a raft with a cover and lashing it to Huck's canoe. Huck asks Jim again why Pap hates him and why he seems to have a special hate for Jim himself. Jim only nods. In the evening, they set out on their raft, keeping an eye out for larger riverboats. One such vessel sneaks up on them, nearly pulling them under, and its wake damages their raft. They bale water from their craft, and though neither of them prays, they make it through without capsizing.

Despite Jim and Huck's wildly different circumstances, they are united by their common need to escape notice. Huck's questions about Pap suggest there is some animosity between him and Jim, though no details are disclosed at this point.



PART 1, CHAPTER 10

Jim and Huck continue their journey downriver. Huck asks why Jim doesn't just cross to the other side, since Illinois is a free state, but Jim doesn't want to leave the boy alone. One night, during a storm, they come upon the wreckage of a steamboat, grounded on a shoal. Huck wants to search the vessel for treasure and provisions, imagining finding a lamp with a genie inside. Jim does not like this plan but eventually relents, staying behind as a lookout.

Jim's unwillingness to leave Huck on his own suggests he genuinely cares for the boy. It is also possible to read his avoidance of free states as skepticism that he will actually be considered "free" there. Huck's excitement over potential treasure emphasizes his youth and suggests he views their journey as an adventure rather than an escape. Jim's caution, on the other hand, shows that he is understandably more suspicious, and has more to lose.



Huck returns in a panic. There are robbers in the steamboat, and two of them are planning to kill the third. Jim and Huck discover their boat has drifted away from the shoal, so they hide. The robbers load their skiff with stolen goods before taking shelter from the storm inside the steamboat. Huck and Jim steal the skiff and return to shore. Huck is thrilled by the jewelry and clothing in the boat, while Jim is secretly excited to find **books** among the plunder. When Huck asks why he is holding the books, Jim replies that he likes the weight of them. Huck remarks that Jim is a mystery to him, calling him the n-word for the first time.

Throughout this ordeal, Huck oscillates between childlike fear and adventurous excitement. Jim hides his own excitement about the books, once again feigning illiteracy and lesser intelligence. This is the first time Jim's performed identity creates distance between himself and Huck, interrupting their sense of camaraderie. This, of course, is the purpose of Jim's act—to uphold the illusion that he is wholly separate from white people. Huck's unnatural use of the n-word suggests he, too, is suddenly aware of their differences but cannot make sense of the racist ideology that affirms them.



PART 1, CHAPTER 11

Huck recalls Tom Sawyer's story about a genie who lives in a lamp and grants three wishes to whoever discovers him. He asks what Jim would wish for. Jim has ruminated on this scenario before and concluded that any wish has the potential to cause negative consequences. He tells Huck that the genie must be white, as it is useless to wish for things he knows won't happen. Huck would wish for adventure, and that all enslaved people were free. After the boy falls asleep, Jim realizes he can read the stolen books without fear, as even Huck will simply assume he is staring at the words rather than comprehending them. Reading a novel, Jim feels he has temporarily escaped his predicament.

Jim seems to view Huck's question about the genie as (at best) a useless thought experiment or (at worst) a trap. Jim implies that Black people like himself know better than to wish, as it is futile to do so. His suffering has stripped him of hope, leaving him understandably disillusioned. Huck's wishes further characterize him as childlike and empathetic. Jim's realization that reading is an unobservable act done in the privacy of one's mind amplifies his sense that reading is the one area where he can claim true freedom. In light of this, books become powerful tools synonymous with liberty.



PART 1, CHAPTER 12

Later in the day, Jim and Huck find their own canoe and raft washed up on shore, and they set out on the river, leaving the robbers' skiff behind. Huck asks Jim what he would choose for a last name, since he doesn't have one. Jim settles on "Golightly," calling himself "James" for the first time. They sleep, with Huck on the raft and Jim in the boat. Jim wakes to the sounds of a party on a nearby steamboat, grateful the people cannot see him in the darkness. He realizes the raft has come unhitched, and Huck is gone. Jim calls for the boy, but he also considers that their separation might make his own situation less complicated.

Jim spots Huck drifting on the raft and pretends to be asleep. The boy ties the two vessels back together and pretends he has been there all along when Jim wakes, telling him their separation was a dream. Jim acts hurt when Huck reveals this prank—claiming a bit of trickery for himself. Huck asks if he is technically stealing Jim, since Jim is Miss Watson's property. Irritated, Jim tells Huck he is not a mule, and says the law has nothing to do with good and evil, since the law makes him a slave. Later, Jim tells Huck he can hear the Ohio River telling him to get a job so he can buy Sadie and Lizzie's freedom.

Huck's line of questioning in this scene indicates he is grappling with the concept of enslavement and its consequences on Jim's identity. The act of naming himself "James Golightly" restores some of Jim's lost autonomy. (While "James" both acknowledges his given name and alters it, the choice of "Golightly" is less clear but may reference a character in another novel by Everett: I Am Not Sidney Poitier.) Jim's relief at no longer having to perform for the vanished Huck draws attention to the way he has become jaded by his experiences.



In pretending to fall for Huck's prank, Jim himself becomes a prankster. Not only is the pretense part of Jim's performance of simple-mindedness, but the deception grants him a certain advantage. Once again, Huck's questions revolve around Jim's identity, this time as Miss Watson's "property." This is the closest Jim comes to condemning slavery in Huck's presence, and his irritation is rooted in the offensive comparison of himself to livestock. It is unclear whether his comment about freeing Sadie and Lizzie is a return to his performance of hope or an actual hope.



PART 1, CHAPTER 13

Jim wakes to find it is daylight and Huck has hidden him beneath a tarp. The boy is being questioned by some white men who are looking for a runaway slave. Huck claims to be fishing with his uncle, who is sick with smallpox. Afraid of getting sick, the men do not investigate Jim's concealed form. They give Huck 10 dollars as charity and tell him to keep an eye out for the slave, who is supposedly dangerous. Jim and Huck return to the river at night to find their canoe stolen. They set out on the raft, but it is broken apart by passing riverboats. The two become separated, adrift in the river.

Huck's quick thinking saves Jim's life in this moment, proving his loyalty. Huck's deception also complicates his character, suggesting a deeper understanding of the world's darkness than his innocent demeanor implies.



PART 1, CHAPTER 14

The river sweeps Jim back to shore. He crawls to a clearing, spreads his **books** out to dry, and falls asleep. When he wakes, there are four Black men nearby, observing him. They tell Jim he is in Illinois, but the white folks who enslave them claim they're in Tennessee. Jim tells them he has run away from Missouri and is being pursued. One of the men, Pierre, seems suspicious of Jim, perhaps worried he will cause trouble or bring bad luck. Another of the men, Josiah, has run away three times and has always been captured. The other two men call themselves Old George and Young George. Jim does not mention Huck.

That Jim manages to save his books indicates their high importance in his eyes. Jim feels immediately safer in the presence of the Black men, assuming they are his allies. Being enslaved in a free state seems to amuse the men more than it bothers them, suggesting they are too cynical to expect anything better. Pierre's suspicion of Jim suggests prior experience of runaways bringing trouble, perhaps even collective punishment. That Jim refrains from mentioning Huck implies that friendship with a white boy may tarnish his reputation among other Black people.



According to the men, some white owners and slaves live in the area, as well as two feuding families, the Grangerfords and the Shepherdsons. Pierre approves of white people killing one another, saying, “The fewer the better.” Jim considers hiding in the woods for a while. Josiah advises him to watch out for dogs and tells him how he and others were beaten as penalty for his attempts to escape. Jim assures the men he can survive on his own, not wanting to get them into trouble. He does ask for a **pencil**, and the men agree to help with this, despite Pierre’s reservations.

Pierre’s indifference toward white people dying indicates that he has dehumanized them the same way white people dehumanize him. Josiah’s story confirms that his enslavers collectively punish enslaved people for the actions of a single person, hence Pierre’s caution around Jim. Jim’s request for a pencil indicates a desire to write more of his story.



PART 1, CHAPTER 15

Jim spends his time in the clearing foraging and **reading**. His thoughts overwhelm him, and he longs to write. The slave narrative of Venture Smith frustrates him, recalling “the tidiness of lies” used to justify slavery. He does not read the Bible, understanding it as a tool of the enemy. Young George returns and gives Jim a **pencil** he has stolen from his master. He implores Jim to tell his story by listening. Jim does not understand, but feels the advice is profound. At night, he hears dogs barking and wonders whether he or the racoon that lives in a nearby tree are their prey.

Jim’s eagerness to write represents his desire to assert his agency through the act of storytelling. While reading grants him a sense of freedom, he is frustrated by the content of his books—even the slave narrative feels too neat, a far cry from his own experiences. Young George’s theft of the pencil feels momentous. Jim treasures it as a tool for regaining his autonomy, but he also seems to dread the consequences of its theft. Young George’s directive to listen is unclear but suggests that Jim ought to consider the collective enslaved voices who have been silenced as he tells his own story.



PART 1, CHAPTER 16

Jim begins to write his life story, calling himself James. With his **pencil**, he writes himself into being, reclaiming some of his stolen autonomy. The other men visit his hideout occasionally, sharing food and discussing what Jim ought to do next. Josiah is considering running away again, but he does not want others beaten on his behalf. Jim knows he will not be able to purchase Sadie and Lizzie as a runaway, and he plans to move on from his hiding place. Departing at night, Jim moves through the woods and comes upon a gathering of slaves and overseers. Young George is being whipped for stealing the master’s pencil. He makes eye contact with Jim, hidden in the trees, and tells him to run. Jim does.

Jim’s act of renaming himself with his pencil is critical. The idea of writing himself “into being” suggests he views his prior existence as incomplete, but he has now been fully realized through the act of writing. Josiah’s concern for the others who might be punished on his behalf highlights how enslavers take advantage of their victims’ sense of community to keep them subjugated. Seeing Young George whipped for stealing the pencil adds nuance to this symbol’s meaning, as the agency it represents now comes with a clear cost.



PART 1, CHAPTER 17

As sunrise approaches, Jim hears angry voices in the woods and hides. Some members of the Grangerford and Shepherdson families are fighting over an engagement, and Jim hears Huck's voice in the ruckus. He pulls the boy down into his hiding place as four men open fire, killing one another. Huck leads Jim to the river, where he has found and fixed up the remnants of their raft. Despite it being daytime, Jim insists they board the raft to get away from the dead white people. Huck asks why Jim is talking funny, saying he doesn't sound like a slave. Jim panics, realizing he has been using his normal voice. He switches back to slave diction, but Huck seems suspicious.

The feud between the Grangerfords and the Shepherdsons is true to the author's source material, Mark Twain's [Adventures of Huckleberry Finn](#) (1885). Jim's fear of being discovered with their bodies points to the tendency of white society in this time period to blame Black people for all crimes, regardless of evidence. Though Huck does not share Jim's worry, his naivety can be read as a product of both his whiteness and his youth. Again, Huck notices the change in Jim's diction, as he has not needed to use slave talk for some time, since he hasn't been around white people as much. That Huck is catching on to Jim's performance suggests the boy is more observant than other white people and that he does not underestimate Jim's intelligence.



PART 1, CHAPTER 18

Traveling on the river again, Huck tells Jim about being taken in by the Grangerfords and witnessing their feud with the Shepherdsons. One morning, they find an old canoe near a small creek on the shore. Huck suggests testing the boat on the creek. Jim stays behind, sensing that the boy is troubled by the violence he witnessed. Jim himself is no stranger to violence, as he lives with the threat of it daily. He thinks of Young George and tries to write with the **pencil** he stole, but he falls asleep. Jim dreams of the philosopher John Locke and calls out the hypocrisy of abandoning his moral principles to write a constitution that justified slavery in southern colonies.

Though Huck relates the tale of the Grangerfords and Shepherdsons as a grand adventure, the violence has disturbed him, tarnishing his innocence. Here, the novel seems to equate whiteness with the ignorance of violence; as an enslaved Black man, Jim has always lived with the threat of bodily harm. While Jim is concerned about Young George's fate, the man's punishment only makes the pencil more precious to him. His imagined argument with John Locke once again highlights the hypocrisy of humanitarian philosophers, who claim to oppose slavery only to approve of its continued existence.



Jim wakes to Huck's voice. The boy returns with two frightened white men aboard the canoe. Hearing dogs, Jim lashes the raft to the canoe, and they float back into the river. The men are polar opposites of one another: one is old and thin, while the other is younger and fatter. Huck tells the men that Jim is his friend, not his slave. The two newcomers are strangers in similar trouble. The young man (the Duke) was selling a shoddy product that stripped teeth of their enamel, while the old man (the King) was preaching about the evils of alcohol when an attendee caught him drinking from his private stash. Both con men were forced to flee before they were caught.

Like Jim, the King and the Duke spend their lives engaged in performance. While Jim's act facilitates his survival, these two men deceive people in order to steal their money. Their appearance, while humorous, further complicates Jim's own situation as a runaway. Huck's insistence that Jim is his friend again highlights the boy's empathy, but it unintentionally places Jim in danger, as white society is automatically suspicious of an unenslaved Black man in this period.



The two grifters consider teaming up, discussing the various cons they employ, like revival preaching, phrenology, and fortune telling. Huck is amazed by the men, and Jim notes the gullibility of white people. The younger man confesses a secret: he is the son of the Duke of Bridgewater, and the rightful heir to that estate. The older man intentionally mispronounces the Duke's title and confesses he, too, is secret royalty: Louis the Seventeenth, the rightful King of France. The King and the Duke discuss collusion, while Jim wonders if Huck knows they are liars. Nevertheless, the men are stuck with them.

While Huck's gullibility may be partially rooted in his youth, Jim blames his whiteness for his naïve response. The Duke and the King's lies seem designed to one-up each other, indicating a shared sense of self-importance. It is unclear whether Huck sincerely falls for their performance, but it seems possible that he wants their lies to be true because it is more interesting. This builds on Jim's perception of white gullibility as willful ignorance.



PART 1, CHAPTER 19

The Duke and the King question Huck and Jim. Seeing how the men suspect Jim is a runaway slave, Huck claims Jim belongs to him, though he is obviously uncomfortable. Huck spins a lie about losing his father and brother in a riverboat accident, leaving him and Jim alone together. The reason they travel at night, according to Huck, is that people keep trying to take Jim away, since Huck is so young. His story fools the con men. A storm makes the river unsafe for travel that night. The King and the Duke insist on finding a town where they can con people out of their money. Huck worries that the men will pretend Jim belongs to them and try to sell him.

Huck continues to wrestle with the idea of Jim's enslavement, which clearly troubles his sense of morality. That he, as a white child, has more social power than Jim, a Black adult, is obviously absurd. Nevertheless, Huck uses his privilege to shield Jim from the men's questionable intentions as much as he can. Though they are liars themselves, the King and the Duke believe Huck's story, bolstering Jim's belief in white gullibility. Huck's prediction that the men will try to sell Jim indicates he is wising up to the more sinister ways of the world.



PART 1, CHAPTER 20

The group finds a town, stowing their canoe and raft to some trees before setting off on foot. The King and the Duke force Jim and Huck to come along, sure they will bolt if left on their own. The King insists on pretending to be Jim's owner. Jim takes note of their path so he can find the way back later, and spots rope scars on a tree branch. The town is nearly empty. The King stops a man, who reports that everyone is attending a revival, giving all their money to a preacher. The King offers to sell Jim to the man, to no avail. The con men head toward the edge of town, seeking the revival.

The King and the Duke easily claim authority over Huck and Jim, forcing them to tag along and pretend that Jim is their slave. Ominously, the King attempts to sell Jim to a passing citizen, destroying any illusion of loyalty to either him or Huck. The rope scars hint that the townsfolk are fond of hanging people they perceive as troublemakers, which does not bode well, given the grifters' plans to make trouble.



Huck is furious the King tried to sell Jim. They come upon a small tent, where 300 people are listening to a preacher, who heals a woman with a physical disability. His accomplices collect the townsfolk's money in baskets. The Duke, inspired, interrupts the preacher's sermon with a speech about his own salvation. The Duke claims he used to be a pirate before coming to the Lord, and Jim and Huck are astounded to see the audience spellbound. Jim notes there are no other enslaved people in the tent. The Duke claims to have converted Jim, though he calls him Caesar. He asks for donations to help continue his good work of preaching the gospel to heathens.

The townsfolk's willingness to give the preacher their money highlights how the desire to believe a lie is sometimes stronger than the desire for truth. Likewise, the Duke's performed piety leaves the audience enraptured despite its falseness. The fact that no one in the audience is Black recalls Jim's conviction that white people are more gullible, and—like the rope-scarred tree—implies that this town is not safe for people of color. The Duke references Jim as a former heathen, knowing he can rely on widespread racist ideology to support his claim.



The King sends Huck through the aisles to collect money from people. The King tries to entertain the crowd with some Shakespeare, but they are confused when the speech he recites is from a Jewish perspective. The preacher attempts to regain control of the crowd, but the Duke carries on about his crimes of piracy. When they see that Huck has collected plenty of money, the King and Duke try to make their exit, but they are caught in their own web of lies. The townsfolk demand their money back, and one man insists that the con men have earned themselves a hanging.

As with Jim's performed slave identity, failing to convince their audience leaves the grifters' lives in danger. The difference, of course, is that the King and the Duke's trickery was born of malicious intent, where Jim's deception is necessary for his survival in white society. In other words, for Jim, the stakes of performance are much higher, which is perhaps why he is better at staying in character than the con men. The townsfolk's readiness to hang someone suggests they find it easy to dehumanize a person to satisfy their desire for violence.



PART 1, CHAPTER 21

Jim and Huck run from the revival tent together, with the King and the Duke close behind. On a storefront in town, they see a wanted poster for a runaway who looks just like Jim. Jim pulls Huck along, but he sees the King and the Duke stop at the poster too. Huck is afraid the con men will try to turn Jim in for the reward money of 300 dollars. Still, the boy worries about what the townsfolk will do to the King and the Duke if they are captured. Jim remembers the route to their raft and unties it just in time to cast off, leaving the King and the Duke on the riverbank.

It is worth noting that Jim is not certain the wanted poster is for him, but he knows that it could still potentially lead to his murder. Huck's ability to feel compassion for the two con men, despite their treachery, speaks to his innocence. Still, even he seems to recognize that the men are likely to prioritize money over Jim's life.



Huck wonders if they ought to save the King and the Duke. Jim is astounded by his innocence and gently reminds Huck that the men will not only turn him in but were also lying to steal people's money. Huck and Jim discuss how people sometimes accept lies over truths that scare them. Huck feels he does this, intentionally forgetting that Jim misses his family and feels things just like he does. Later, Jim talks about knowing Huck's mother. She was a kind woman, but Jim is reluctant to call her pretty. Huck asks if Jim was friends with his mother, but Jim distracts him by pointing out a steamboat that has caught fire.

Huck's trusting nature, Jim knows, will get them into more trouble—here, cynicism and distrust are qualities that help Jim survive. His assertion that sometimes lies are more palatable than the truth explains his own performed identity: white people are more comfortable believing the lie of his ignorance than they are with the truth of his intelligence. That Huck self-reflects and admits to dehumanizing Jim indicates a surprising willingness to acknowledge his mistakes and change. The way Jim avoids Huck's questions about his mother suggest he is keeping some secret from the boy.



PART 1, CHAPTER 22

Jim and Huck continue traveling at night. One evening, they find the Duke and the King waiting by their raft, having stolen a boat and caught up to them. The men know that Jim is a runaway and have concocted a plan to sell him repeatedly, having him escape each time only to be sold again. As a minor, Huck cannot claim to own a slave, and the King declares, "Possession is nine-tenths of the law," meaning he owns Jim by virtue of claiming to own him. The Duke removes his belt to beat Jim, who takes the lashes rather than see Huck hurt in his place. The men remark that Jim does not seem to experience pain like a human man.

The knowledge that Jim is a runaway emboldens the Duke and the King, who treat him even more callously than before, knowing how much he has to lose. Their plan to exploit Jim is easy to implement because what the King says is true—anyone who sees him with Jim will assume he is Jim's enslaver. The Duke's violence is wholly unnecessary and merely exhibits the depth of his wickedness. His remark that Jim does not feel pain reveals his racist perception of Black people as something other than human.



PART 1, CHAPTER 23

The King and the Duke force Huck and Jim to cook catfish for them while they plan to stop for a drink in the next town. The King remarks that there's something different about Jim, but he does not elaborate. They reach the next town, which is half in Missouri and half in Illinois. The Duke chides Jim for limping, as an injured or physically disabled slave is harder to sell. The men tell Huck and Jim to sit directly outside the saloon while they have a drink. Huck proposes running, but Jim is too wounded and does not trust that making it to the free side of town will actually deliver him to freedom.

Huck wonders what will happen if Jim is sold and cannot escape. Jim replies that his life will not be that different, except he will belong to someone else. They discuss finding a shortcut to the river and ask a man who comes out of the saloon for directions. He is too drunk to be of any help. Jim declares that, if they do run, it should be back the way they came, toward the raft. Huck has no running left in him. Jim knows he can always run, but that escape is another matter. He tries to keep in mind his goal of freeing Lizzie and Sadie.

The King's scrutiny suggests he can sense Jim's intelligence, despite his performed ignorance. That the Duke criticizes Jim for limping when he is the one who wounded him is bitterly ironic. Jim's suffering leaves him even more dejected and hopeless than before, evidenced by his lack of trust in the supposedly "free" side of town.



Despite Jim's running away, he once again finds himself a captive. The bitter truth is that, for all his effort, he has not managed to change very much about his situation, as his identity and story are still bound by slavery. Reflecting that he can always run if it is necessary shows how much of Jim's existence is ruled by the need to survive, and how elusive true escape is. Without the hope of reuniting with his family, Jim feels he might give up on freedom entirely.



PART 1, CHAPTER 24

The King and the Duke emerge from the saloon and take Huck and Jim to the town's livery. There, they meet Easter, a Black blacksmith. He acquiesces to the con men's request and chains Jim to a post so he cannot run away. The King and the Duke leave. Huck hates them for their treatment of Jim. Jim assures Easter that Huck is on his side, and the blacksmith produces another key and frees Jim so he can sleep more comfortably, promising to lock them up again in the morning. Huck thanks Easter.

When Huck is asleep, Easter drops the performed slave dialect and asks Jim what the boy is to him. Jim calls Huck his friend. Easter looks closely and asks if Huck is white, claiming he sees "a lot of things in that face." Jim cuts him off, asking for water. Easter remarks that white folks "don't see like we do" before heading to bed. Huck speaks up, having been secretly awake this whole time. He thinks Jim doesn't trust him, because of the way he changes his speech around him. Jim tells Huck he trusts him with his life. Huck says he understands why Jim talks the way he does. Jim calls him a smart boy.

Chaining Jim up at the livery emphasizes that the Duke and the King think of him as livestock. Huck's hatred of the men he once admired shows that he is loyal to Jim despite their differences. Easter's actions demonstrate his solidarity with Jim as a fellow enslaved Black man.



The fact that slave talk is so widespread suggests that it is effective as coded communication between enslaved people. Easter questions Huck's white identity and seems to imply there is more between the boy and Jim than is obvious at surface level. Jim's quick change of subjects indicates he is uncomfortable with the other man's line of questioning. The idea that white people don't see everything Black people do further implies a kind of pervasive willful ignorance. While Huck initially views Jim's speech alterations as a kind of betrayal, he claims to understand his reasoning. Even though Huck does not elaborate, Jim senses the boy is remarkably perceptive in comparison to the aforementioned unaware white folks.



PART 1, CHAPTER 25

Jim wakes to see the Duke standing over him, furious that he is no longer chained up. He calls Easter over, but Huck claims to have slipped the shackles off Jim. Nevertheless, the Duke clearly means to beat Easter, and Jim, too, when he tries to interfere. He takes a whip and hits Easter across the chest and arm. Easter's owner, Mr. Wiley, appears, enraged that the Duke dared to harm his slave. Seeing Easter's injury, Mr. Wiley demands Jim work for him until his own slave recovers. The Duke agrees, and he and the King take Huck as collateral in case Jim tries to run away.

Compared to his benign and humorous introduction, the Duke is now clearly enjoying being violent toward those he has dehumanized. When Mr. Wiley—an actual enslaver—arrives, the Duke shrinks back into himself, suggesting this display of power is just another performance. He submits to Wiley's demands out of fear of being found out as a fraud once again.



PART 1, CHAPTER 26

Jim finds this latest separation from Huck jarring. Wiley tells Jim if he works well, he'll be treated well. When they are alone, Easter asks Jim if he taught Huck to pass for white. Jim insists he is mistaken, that Huck is as white as both his parents. Easter lets it go and begins to teach Jim how to forge horseshoes. He reports that somewhere upriver, a slave was lynched for stealing a **pencil**. The story leaves Jim shaken. Easter remarks that white people forget how much time slaves have to sit and think while they work. Jim agrees, saying white folks don't seem to think slaves even talk to one another.

Jim fears for Huck's safety, showing how close the two have grown during their journey. Easter's assumption that Huck is not fully white is jarring, as is the fervor of Jim's denial. Jim assumes that the enslaved man who was lynched is Young George, and the pencil—though unused for some time—becomes even more significant. Jim's conversation with Easter highlights how white people assume enslaved Black people are too simple to be capable of complex thought, planning, and conversation. In this way, their tendency to dehumanize enslaved people leads to the naïve and false assumption that those people cannot plot against them.



Jim tells Easter about Denmark Vesey, who was lynched for planning a slave revolt in South Carolina. He wonders if Wiley would chase him if he ran away, since he is not legally his property. Easter continues his blacksmithing instruction. He asks Jim how many people know, but he doesn't respond when Jim asks him to elaborate. Jim shows Easter the **pencil**, and the older man tells him he must write, for Young George's sake. Later, Wiley comes to check on Jim's progress and asks the men to sing. They do, and suddenly a group of white men appear dressed in matching dark suits. They introduce themselves as the Virginia Minstrels, led by Daniel Decatur Emmett.

Denmark Vesey is a historical figure who died just as Jim describes in 1822. Referencing him here reiterates the idea that evidence of Black intelligence disturbs white people so much that they punish it with death. Easter's vague questions throughout his conversation with Jim imply some secret knowledge about him and Huck, which has not yet been revealed to the reader. Rather than blame Jim for Young George's death, Easter implores him to write, thinking—like Jim—this is the only way to make the other man's sacrifice worthwhile.



PART 1, CHAPTER 27

Daniel Decatur Emmett introduces himself and his company to Wiley as musicians. They are performing at the town hall but have lost their tenor, who fell out of a moving train. Emmett heard Jim's "exquisite voice" and would like to purchase him from Wiley. The white man hesitates, since Jim is not technically his property. But Emmett offers him 200 dollars, and Wiley accepts. Emmett says Jim will perform on stage with the rest of the minstrels in blackface—wearing boot polish on his face, pretending to be Black (though Jim, of course, will not be pretending). Though Emmett does not ask Jim's opinion during this transaction, he does shake Jim's hand, which shocks everyone.

Though Emmett's interest in Jim is based on his "exquisite" singing ability, he ignores Jim completely while purchasing him, communicating that he does not see him as an equal. The minstrels' brand of entertainment involves two performances: one musical, and one racial. It is worth noting that Jim will be the only man in the company who is actually Black, while the others will pretend. This unusual scenario complicates themes of identity and performance. Despite Emmett's aloofness, he does shake Jim's hand, indicating he is a different sort of white man than Wiley.



PART 1, CHAPTER 28

Jim accompanies the Virginia Minstrels to their camp outside of town. A trombonist named Cassidy gives Jim some coffee and speaks with him in an approximation of slave dialect, as if he is practicing. Confused, Jim asks Emmett what work he wants him to do. Emmett claims that he has hired Jim—instead of purchasing him—to sing when the time comes. He and the other men are opposed to slavery, though they are not actively seeking to abolish it.

Cassidy's performance of slave dialect—which is itself a performance designed to satisfy white expectations of Black people—is extremely ironic. Emmett's claim that Jim is his employee rather than his slave sounds too good to be true, highlighting again how Jim's experiences have forced him to move through life carefully and with great suspicion. It is possible that Emmett thinks treating Jim as an equal will make him more loyal, but his ulterior motives are not yet clear.



Cassidy retrieves his trombone and begins teaching Jim some of the minstrels' songs, like "Ole Dan Tucker" and "The Blue-Tail Fly." The lyrics are written in a rough approximation of slave diction, and Jim sings along with the chorus. He does not believe that Emmett has hired him, as he witnessed Wiley sign a bill of sale. Another man gives Jim a suit so he will match the rest of the company, and he is allowed to change in private. Cassidy helps Jim with his tie, and Emmett approves.

All of Emmett's songs are written in slave dialect, suggesting that the purpose of the minstrels' performances is to emulate—and probably mock—Black people. This alone is enough to cast doubt on Emmett's claim that he has hired Jim as an employee, as is the bill of sale, which certifies that Jim legally belongs to Emmett.



PART 1, CHAPTER 29

A man named Norman sits Jim down to put bootblack on his face. When they are alone, Norman tells Jim to "drop the slave talk." Jim is shocked when Norman tells him he is a former slave, as the man's skin is light enough to pass for white. The rest of the minstrels do not know Norman is Black. He tells Jim the minstrels' show makes fun of Black folks to entertain other white people, singing songs they think slaves would like. Jim is particularly amused to hear the minstrels perform a cakewalk, which is a dance that Black people have used to make fun of white people. Norman claims white folks have no awareness of their own potential to be mocked.

Norman's ability to pass as a white man is another kind of performance, especially since the rest of the minstrels are ignorant of his identity. His knowledge of slave talk seems to Jim like proof of his Blackness. The minstrels' practice of mocking enslaved Black people is dehumanizing, suggesting Emmett is not as progressive as he pretends. Norman's assertion that white people mock Black people without thinking of themselves as mockable highlights again their lack of self-awareness. In a sense, according to Norman, white people are so desperate to think of themselves as separate from Black people, that they never consider their own potential to be ridiculed.



Norman performs with the minstrels because he needs the money. He wants to return to Virginia and buy his wife from her enslaver. Jim wonders if Emmett will pay him too. Norman says the musician has never knowingly hired a Black man before, so he cannot say. Emmett comes over to inspect Norman's work and tells him to keep practicing the songs. According to Norman, Jim will not be allowed in the auditorium if they know he is actually Black, so he is disguising him as a white man disguised as a Black man. Confused as he is, Jim allows himself to hope that he might earn enough money to buy Sadie and Lizzie.

Although Norman travels with the minstrels out of necessity, he views their performances with contempt, indicating that he still thinks of himself as a Black man, even in the all-white company. Jim allows himself to hope that Emmett is true to his word and will pay him as he does the other employees. The fact that Jim must disguise himself as a white man in blackface emphasizes that, in the context of theatrical performance, Blackness is only welcome as a form of comedic entertainment. Authentic Blackness, in the eyes of white society, can only serve the purpose of enslaved labor.



PART 1, CHAPTER 30

Jim feels absurd as he and the other men march down the town's main street, singing along to Emmett's songs. Appearing to the gathered townsfolk as a white man painted Black, Jim finds the white citizens make eye contact with him, as if seeking to "share this moment of mocking me, mocking darkies, laughing at the poor slaves." One woman seems to admire him specifically. The minstrels enter the auditorium and perform more songs. Jim learns the simple choruses quickly, but he is disturbed the communal white enthusiasm. He reminds himself that he is fooling them. When the show is over, a white woman (Polly) approaches Jim, and he has never been "more frightened by a creature, human or otherwise."

Under the guise of whiteness approximating Blackness, Jim is granted access to a new kind of interaction with white society. He does not enjoy this inclusion because, unbeknownst to them, he does not share in their enthusiastic mockery of Black people. While Jim tries to take comfort in deceiving them, this performance is also uniquely dangerous, as Jim is a Black man in an exclusively white space. His fear of Polly is rooted in the knowledge that, if he is discovered speaking to a white woman, he will likely be killed.



Polly tries to flirt with Jim. Her father compliments Jim's singing but insists his daughter will not be taking up with "show-bizness folks." He is amazed by the authenticity of Jim's hair, which Emmett claims is a wig. Polly's father tells Emmett that none of them could pass for real slaves, claiming he can smell a Black person a half mile away. Jim leaves quickly, noting that Norman is also terrified. Emmett recognizes the danger of Jim being discovered, but he seems amused by the prospect. Jim reflects on the anxiety and anger he felt when Polly's father touched his hair and his complicated feelings about Emmett, who surely will not let him leave the minstrels after paying 200 dollars for him.

Polly's interest in Jim places him in significant danger. Polly's father's comments about the authenticity of Jim's appearance hints that his disguise is not as convincing as he hoped. As a white man, Emmett does not seem to grasp the full implications of Jim being discovered—only Norman, the only other Black man, shares Jim's fear. Jim views his anxiety and anger as luxuries, suggesting that his sense of autonomy is getting stronger, as he no longer feels the need to suppress such emotions. Jim's musings about his strange relationship to Emmett foreshadow future conflict.



PART 1, CHAPTER 31

Jim lies down to sleep in a tent with Norman and a white man named Big Mike. During the night, he swats at an insect near his ear only to feel a human hand touching his hair. Startled, Jim jumps up to find Polly's father in the tent, repeating that he just wanted to touch Jim's wig once more. Emmett appears, equally alarmed. Polly's father asks why Jim sleeps in makeup and his wig when everyone else has washed. Emmett asks if Polly knows her father sneaks around touching men while they sleep. At this insinuation, Polly's father runs away, but not before insisting something is "amiss."

Just as Polly's father felt entitled to touch Jim's hair in the previous chapter, now he feels entitled to an explanation for Jim's appearance. That a slight suspicion led this man to such bold action suggests privileged arrogance. Emmett is able to defuse the situation by threatening Polly's father's reputation. It is worth noting that his suspicion that Jim is actually Black is what makes him feel entitled to touch Jim without his consent.



Emmett orders everyone to pack up, worried Polly's father will return. He apologizes to Jim, which confuses him. Emmett sings Jim a new song titled "Dixie's Land," which romanticizes the South. When Emmett denies ownership of Jim, Jim asks if he could just leave right now, if he wanted to. To this, Emmett asserts that he paid 200 dollars for Jim, and he ought to work for him long enough to pay back that amount. At a dollar a day, Jim reasons it will take him 199 days to pay Emmett back. He asks the musician if he is distinguishing between chattel slavery and bonded slavery, but he continues to speak in slave diction. Surprised, Emmett asks Jim to repeat himself, but he declines.

Emmett's apology momentarily suggests that he views Jim as the victim in the situation with Polly's father. Still, he unapologetically idealizes the lives of enslaved people in the South and implies that Jim is obligated to work for him until his "debt" is paid off, proving that he still views Jim as more of a commodity than a person. Jim's slave talk clashes with his sophisticated question, momentarily exposing his intellect. Jim's frustration is the likeliest cause for this slip-up, as Emmett's disapproval for slavery does not stop him from hypocritically stripping Jim of his autonomy as an indentured servant.



PART 1, CHAPTER 32

The minstrels set up camp in a logging town, where slaves work while white men holding whips stand around chatting. Emmett leaves to set up a performance. Jim asks Big Mike if Emmett is a good man, and if it's true that the rest of them don't believe in slavery. Big Mike seems indifferent on the subject. When Emmett returns, he recommends Jim remain in the camp for this performance, as the townsfolk will kill him if they discover he is Black, and they can't afford another tenor. Norman seems to know that Jim will not be at the camp when they return. After the men leave, Jim steals some food and Emmett's song notebook and runs hard away from the camp.

Big Mike's indifference toward the subject of slavery makes it clear that no one is going to stand up to Emmett on Jim's behalf. That Emmett trusts Jim to be left alone at the camp while the others perform implies that he assumes Jim's loyalty based on his relatively kind treatment. In reality, Emmett is just another man denying Jim his freedom, and he treats him as such.



PART 2, CHAPTER 1

Norman catches up with Jim in the woods, unable to stand the minstrels any longer. When Emmett discovered Jim gone, Norman says, he started cursing Black people like any other enslaver. While Norman sleeps, Jim concocts a plan. Since both he and Norman want to buy their families, Jim proposes Norman pose as a white enslaver, selling Jim repeatedly to make some money. It is the same plan the Duke and the King thought to enact. Though dangerous, Norman agrees their situation cannot get any worse. He estimates his wife will cost 1000 dollars, as she is "good breeding stock." Jim reads a racist lyric from Norman's notebook and shares his own desire to write. The men head south.

Discovering that Emmett's compassion for enslaved Black people was just another performance pushes Norman to abandon the troupe. Although Jim's plan is the same one the con men came up with, he trusts Norman more as a fellow Black man, for whom the stakes of discovery are equally high. Emmett's racist lyrics emphasize the impossibility of Norman and Jim remaining loyal to this man who mocks them and denies their humanity.



After a few days, the men stop in a town called Bluebird. Jim pretends to be Norman's slave, calling him "Massa Brown." They see some other Black people in town, like an old woman churning butter at the general store. An old white woman hears Jim talking, which alarms her. Norman assures her that Jim can only grunt and whine, like an animal. He is nervous talking to white people, even if he is able to pass. Jim wonders if Norman is just a crazy white man who imagines himself Black, or if he will abandon Jim to his fate after selling him, regardless of race. Jim gives Norman his notebook to carry, but he keeps his **pencil** safe in his pocket.

In this scene, Jim and Norman must perform different roles based on their skin color. Jim falls back into the familiar slave dialect, while Norman must affect a white persona, using his light skin to their advantage. The white woman confirms that the idea of an intelligent slave is frightening to some people who take comfort in thinking of Black people as animals. Jim's sudden misgivings about Norman point to the difficulty of trusting anyone in a world that has consistently dehumanized him. Taking comfort in the pencil's presence suggests Jim's main source of hope is his ability to self-define through writing.



PART 2, CHAPTER 2

Jim has removed his shirt, showing off the scars Judge Thatcher gave him for saying hello to a white woman who greeted him first. He and Norman run into the town's constable, who also sells eggs and serves as a teacher and postmaster. Norman does his best to entice the constable to buy Jim to help with all his jobs, but the man turns him down, thinking that having a slave will be like keeping a pet. He recommends seeking out Old Man Henderson, who keeps slaves and runs a sawmill. Afterwards, Jim remarks that Norman is very good at pretending to be white, which unsettles him.

Jim's single previous beating is unquestionably unjust, and explains his terror when Polly tried to speak to him as a minstrel. Despite Norman's nerves, he gives a convincing performance to the constable. It is possible this unsettles Jim because it implies that Norman could easily betray him and commit fully to the pretense of whiteness. The authenticity of Norman's act also vaguely reflects the idea that power—even that which is feigned—always corrupts those who emulate it.



PART 2, CHAPTER 3

Jim and Norman go to the general store for food. An enslaved Black woman at the store seems to signal that the biscuits are no good, so they purchase a potato. They split the potato after roasting it and discuss seeking out Henderson, the sawmill owner. After a brief rest, Norman discovers Jim writing with his **pencil** in Emmett's notebook. Jim considers tearing out the musician's songs, but knowing they would still exist makes such destruction feel pointless. Jim tells Norman to call him February when they meet Henderson so that there's less risk he'll recognize him from the runaway posters. He gives Norman his notebook to look after until he escapes.

Even though she doesn't speak to them, the Black woman at the general store provides what little assistance she can to Norman and Jim, seemingly motivated by a sense of racial loyalty. As Jim writes his own story, it becomes clear that he has succeeded in his quest for self-determination, as he has written his own legacy, which the reader is now perusing.



Norman and Jim find the sawmill. They see several slaves missing fingers working with saws and timber. The only white man, Henderson, approaches Norman, who endears himself to the man by mocking slaves. He tells the man Jim's name is February and offers to sell him. Henderson asks Jim how he feels about Norman selling him, which is strange. Jim declares that he is Norman's property, so he can do with him what he wants. Henderson and Norman haggle until Jim is sold for 350 dollars. Henderson calls a slave named Luke to give Jim some water and put him to work. Jim gives Norman one last look before being led away.

The way Norman ingratiate himself to Henderson demonstrates how mutual dislike can be the basis for alliance, particularly in systems of oppression. Henderson's question to Jim feels like a trap designed to test how submissive Jim is. Though this is not the first time Jim has been sold in the course of the novel, this is the first time he has willingly given himself over to the danger of enslavement, thereby taking a more active role in determining his fate.



PART 2, CHAPTER 4

When they are alone, Luke asks Jim if Norman beat him, and assures him that Henderson will. Nevertheless, Luke considers Henderson a good master. Based on this and Luke's numerous wounds, Jim senses the other man has been beaten into submission. Out in the yard, Jim is put to work on the pit saw, where he works with another man named Sammy. The saw is dull and therefore more dangerous. Later, Henderson summons Jim for his lashes, and calls him a backtalker for questioning him. He ties Jim to a post and whips him until he passes out.

Jim wakes to find Sammy watching over him. Jim tries to orient himself, preparing to run without crossing Luke, whom he does not trust. Jim realizes Sammy is a young girl when she lifts her shirt to show her scars, and he thinks of Lizzie. Unable to bear the thought of what Henderson is doing to Sammy, Jim offers to take her with him. They run immediately, sneaking past the sleeping Luke. Sammy leads them toward town, and they make it to the clearing where Norman should be waiting. Not seeing his friend, Jim leaves Sammy behind and gets closer to town. Worried Norman has betrayed him, Jim is heading back to the clearing when he hears Sammy screaming.

Even though Luke is also enslaved, Jim does not trust him because he has accepted Henderson's violent treatment as fair and good. Here, the novel highlights how constant dehumanization can wear a person down until they accept a terrible situation. Henderson's refusal to maintain his tools signifies a disregard for the health of his slaves. He doles out Jim's unearned punishment as if it is part of an established routine, one designed to make him more willing to submit without complaint.



Jim's risky decision to take Sammy with him is due to her resemblance to his own daughter, Lizzie, and his intense love for his family. Still, he gives her a choice, which is likely the most agency she has ever possessed. That Jim does not need to ask to know that Henderson is assaulting Sammy indicates that this horrible experience is, sadly, common for enslaved women. Luke's sleeping position in the center of the camp suggests Jim's instincts were right, and he acts as Henderson's loyal guard.



PART 2, CHAPTER 5

Jim rushes back to where he left Sammy and tackles the man with her. It is Norman. He has bought food for them to share. Jim explains that he stole Sammy to save her from Henderson's terrible deeds, and Norman understands. Sammy does not seem to believe Norman is a Black man. They run south, keeping away from the river, pursued by dogs. Jim's wounds slow him down, and eventually he can go no farther. Sammy goes to gather bee balm for Jim's back while Norman asks him what he did to get beaten. Frustrated, Jim tells him there was no reason. Sammy returns, and Jim passes out after tending to his wounds.

Again, the fact that both Norman and Jim assume that Sammy has been assaulted implies that such violence is commonplace under slavery. Sammy is nervous around Norman because his light skin casts doubt on his identity as a Black man, and he looks more like one of her oppressors than an ally. Jim implies that Norman's search for a reason behind his beating is ridiculous, since—according to the logic of enslavers—an enslaved person's existence is enough of a reason to dehumanize them.



PART 2, CHAPTER 6

Jim wakes, and the three fugitives plan to continue their journey toward the river. Norman remarks that crossing the river will land them in a slave state, but to Jim it makes no difference. Sammy agrees, saying the only place they can ever be is slavery. She asks why Norman identifies as Black when he can pass for white, and he responds that he does not want to be "one of them." They run across the terrain, finally reaching the Mississippi, which Sammy has never seen. Neither she nor Norman can swim, so they make plans to build a raft, assuming they will be captured unless they cross the water. Norman goes off in search of rope.

Jim and Sammy both assert there is no difference between slave and free states, pointing to their general disillusionment with the world. As Sammy describes it, slavery is an inescapable part of her existence, integral to her identity. Because he can pass as white, Norman has more choice than Jim or Sammy, but he understandably associates whiteness with cruelty, and feels loyal to those who share his experiences as an enslaved person.



Sammy tells Jim she was born at the mill, and Henderson has raped her since she was little. Again, Jim imagines Lizzie and is enraged. They arrange wood for the raft and wait. Norman returns with rope, but in a panic—Henderson is coming. The enslaver appears before they can tie the raft together, and Jim shoves them all into the river clinging to logs. They drift apart as Henderson shoots at them from the bank. Jim is able to get hold of Sammy and Norman and lash their logs together. Norman cannot understand why Henderson would shoot them, since “You can’t work a dead slave.” Jim reminds him, “They hate us.” Sammy is limp in Jim’s arms as they float downriver.

The river deposits the group onto a small beach. Jim carries the lifeless Sammy and sees that she has been shot and killed. Norman says Jim should have left her behind, but he disagrees—Sammy was already dead when he found her. Though Jim does not believe in God, he decides to bury Sammy in case she did. He and Norman dig a grave for her on the beach and send her off with a short prayer. Jim knows the river will uncover her body sooner or later, and he muses that it will “claim us all in due time.” He tells Norman he’ll never be a slave again.

PART 2, CHAPTER 7

Jim and Norman move into the brush for warmth and sleep. Jim wakes to find Emmett’s notebook on his chest, soaked but safe. Jim cannot stop thinking about Sammy. He tells Norman they will steal a boat and travel north. They walk through the woods until they spot a skiff near a trotline. Stealing some fish for their dinner, Jim and Norman wait until the boat’s owners—a man and a boy—come to check their line before dark. Then, they fashion some sticks into paddles and untie the skiff, floating off into the river.

Norman is very nervous on the boat. Jim tries to steer them toward the opposite shore. Spotting a riverboat, he instructs Norman to paddle close to the larger vessel, hoping they can climb aboard. Spinning out of control in the boat’s wake, Jim sees the vessel’s paddle is mounted on the side, threatening to chop them to bits. He manages to grab hold of a rope and haul himself and Norman up onto a deck. Up above, they can hear passengers reacting to their skiff being crushed by the paddle. Jim leads Norman through a hatch to the engine room, where they hide.

Even when injustice and violence are commonplace experiences, they still provoke extreme reactions, as exhibited by Jim in this scene. Henderson’s anger, on the other hand, seems motivated by hatred and a desire to subjugate the escapees in death if not in life. That Henderson would prefer to see them dead than recaptured or free is proof that he does not view enslaved people as humans with utility, but as beings who must be controlled at all costs.



Although Sammy was not submissive like Luke, Henderson had already taken so much of her vitality and will that Jim feels she has been dead for a long while. Though he does not state outright that death is preferable to the abuse Sammy suffered, it is suggested. Jim’s compassion for the young girl is evident in the careful act of burying her. His refusal to return to slavery implies that he, too, would rather die than lose his autonomy again.



That Norman kept Jim’s notebook safe indicates a mutual understanding of the importance of narrative in their struggle to regain agency. Jim’s haunting thoughts of Sammy overlap with his continued concern for his family’s wellbeing.



Though brief, this scene shows Jim treating Norman like a child, intentionally keeping him unaware of the boat’s danger so as not to frighten him. Here, Jim’s disenchantment with the world is beneficial, as it helps him face great danger without shock or hesitation.



PART 2, CHAPTER 8

Another enslaved man (Brock) discovers Jim and Norman in the engine room and tries to get them to leave. Norman pretends again to be Jim's owner and tells Brock to mind his own business. Jim is not sure they can trust the man, even though he is enslaved. Brock returns to again insist that they leave the engine room, or else he will get into trouble. Norman asks where the passenger trunks are kept so he can change out of his wet clothes and investigate the upper decks as a white man. Brock tells them "Mistuh Corey" will throw him in the fire if they are caught, but another reprimand from Norman sends him away.

Norman finds dry clothes in one of the trunks and heads to the upper decks to investigate. Brock tells Jim to help shovel coal into the engine, since he refuses to leave. Brock enjoys his work, smiling while he shovels. Even though there are no white people around, he says "massa" instead of "master," which irks Jim. Brock suspects something is strange between Jim and Norman, who talk to each other like equals. Brock works alone in the engine room and claims to take short naps between shovels. He does not even leave the windowless room when the boat makes port. Jim asks when "Massa Corey" comes down, but Brock ignores him.

Brock tells Jim the boiler has been making a new noise and shaking, but he doesn't know why. A bell rings, and Brock excitedly fiddles with the boat's wheels and levers. The boiler makes a sound like a woman crying, but Brock insists Corey doesn't need to know about this. Corey leaves food for Brock outside the door every day. Brock begins to sing about being a slave on the boat while Jim rests. Jim thinks of Norman and his own ever-present anger. He wakes to find Brock eating some cornbread and asks if he told Corey about him. Brock avoids the question, confirming Jim's suspicion that the master does not even talk to Brock, treating him like a dog.

Norman returns from the upper decks. Jim asks him what he found, provoking Brock's scrutiny. He shovels coal with increased fervor as the two men talk. Emmett is on the boat, and Norman thinks the trombonist Cassidy may have recognized him. The boat itself is packed with people fleeing home to the north—the slave states are trying to leave the union, and there are rumors of war. Jim reports that Brock loves being a slave, and he shares his suspicion that "Massa Corey" does not exist, or is long dead. Brock continues to shovel coal as the boiler emits a sustained whine. Norman says that something is wrong.

Since his interaction with Luke, Jim is more cautious around enslaved Black people, realizing he cannot assume they are allies. That Norman's performance is enough to convince and control Brock (despite his disheveled appearance) highlights the power of his skin color. Brock's actions suggest he is very loyal to his enslaver and views his job as essential.



The immediate tension between Brock and Jim stems from Jim's refusal to submit to Brock in his own realm. Brock himself seems to have committed so fully to his enslavement that his slave talk is not a performance but actually his normal dialect. Like Luke, Brock accepts his situation as good and right and has no desire for autonomy. While this may seem like devotion, it is possible that Brock, knowing that wishing for change will not actually change anything, throws himself into his work as a way of coping with unalterable reality.



The more Brock talks about never leaving the engine room, the more Jim suspects that Corey exists only in the other man's imagination. Brock's fervent enthusiasm for his work disturbs Jim, who is beginning to view the other man as both an enemy and the inevitable result of slavery's vicious dehumanization. His anger seems to be directed less at Brock than at the immoral and violent system that broke him down into such a submissive state.

It is worth noting that Jim is more comfortable breaking character around Brock, who poses less of a threat than a white person noticing Jim's performance. The potential war does not concern Jim—here again, the novel calls attention to the way Jim is enslaved wherever he goes, his identity unchanged by the possibility of war. Jim's speculation that Corey is a figment of Brock's imagination shows how completely the other man has been subjugated, requiring no supervision to continue his work.



PART 2, CHAPTER 9

The engine room shakes, and the bell rings seven times. Brock does not know what this means, but he continues shoveling. Jim tells Norman the man is crazy, and Brock confronts them, demanding to know why a slave would talk to his master that way. Norman admits that he is not white. The boiler screams louder, and a rivet shoots out. Brock looks terrified and curses. The next thing Jim knows, he is waking up in the river. Passengers—alive and dead—float all around him. He calls out for Norman and sees him clinging to a plank in the water. Another voice calls Jim's name—it is Huck, also treading water. Jim is forced to choose between them.

Perhaps because he is also enslaved, Brock is able to see that Norman and Jim's relationship is not typical. The explosive result of his fast shoveling is somewhat ironic, suggesting that Brock's devotion to his task—which was cultivated by his enslavers—essentially backfired and led to disaster. Finding himself forced to choose between saving Huck or Norman, Jim imagines himself in a real-life philosophical conundrum similar to those employed by Voltaire and Locke. Jim knows there can be no just solution to his predicament, and the fact that he still must choose is yet another injustice.



PART 3, CHAPTER 1

Jim drags Huck onto the beach, having saved his life. He shoves the boy toward the woods, out of sight of the other survivors. Huck tells Jim about the rumored war between the northern and southern states. The King and the Duke were with him on the boat, trying to escape to Ohio before fighting broke out. Huck asks Jim about Norman, who was calling to him in the water and has probably drowned. He asks repeatedly why Jim chose to save him instead. Fed up with slave diction and tired of the lies, Jim admits that he saved Huck because Huck is Jim's son. Huck is confused, but Jim is too exhausted to explain and falls asleep. When he wakes, Huck interrogates him.

It is worth noting that the white people on the boat are more worried about the war than Jim, though enslavement is supposedly the inciting issue for the conflict. Jim's indifference points again to his lack of faith in legal avenues toward freedom, preferring to make his own way there. Jim's weariness implies that his performance is unsustainable, and he gives it up. While the reveal that Jim is Huck's biological father explains why he chose to save the boy instead of Norman, it raises questions about Jim's reasons for keeping this secret and the extent of his loyalty.



Huck asks if Pap knew the truth of his paternity, and he wants to know if he is an n-word. Jim assures Huck he can be whatever he wants to be, and reveals that Pap was the dead body in the house. All these secrets, combined with Jim's shifting speech, make Huck conclude Jim is a liar. Later, Huck tries using slave diction, but he sounds ridiculous. Jim says Huck can continue to live as a white boy, that he does not have to help Jim rescue the rest of his family. When Huck asks why he should believe anything Jim says, Jim tells him, "Belief has nothing to do with truth." Huck calls Jim a liar and declares that he is not an n-word.

Learning the truth of his parentage pushes Huck into an identity crisis, unsure whether he is white or Black. Jim affirms Huck's ability to choose his own identity, encouraging the boy to embrace the autonomy he himself has had to fight for. Huck feels that Jim has betrayed him by keeping secrets, even if those secrets protected him from suffering. The boy's attempts to speak like Jim hint at his deep desire for belonging, which makes Jim's indifference to Huck's decision (whether to live as a white or Black boy) painful. Jim's statement about belief can be read as a reflection on the way white people in particular deny unpleasant truths (like Black intelligence), as well as a directive that Huck do the same with regards to his identity. That Huck uses a hateful slur reveals his confusion and pain and suggests he has lost some more of his youthful innocence.



PART 3, CHAPTER 2

Jim thinks of the rumors he's heard of an underground railroad. Looking out at the beach, he sees—miraculously—his notebook washed ashore. People see his Black form, unattended by a white person, and assume he is robbing dead bodies. Emmett is on the beach and shouts that Jim is robbing him again. Only when Jim begins to run does he realize Huck is with him. The boy insists they stay together, but Jim disagrees, insisting Huck return to Missouri. Huck takes the fact that Jim can read and write as more proof of his lying nature, but still demands to accompany him north. Knowing that Huck's apparent whiteness may keep him safer than he'd be on his own, Jim relents.

Emmett's brief reappearance sees him demanding his notebook, perhaps symbolizing his attempts to appropriate more Black experiences (though he does not know that Jim has written in the book). Huck's persistent loyalty signifies that, despite his anger at Jim, he cares for his father. Furthermore, Huck now has a deeper understanding of the advantages of passing as a white person and realizes that he—though a child—may be able to use that privilege to protect Jim.



PART 3, CHAPTER 3

Finding no trotlines, Jim and Huck decide to dog for a catfish. Jim wades into the river and sticks his arm in a hole in the bank. He has never done this and is nervous. A catfish locks onto Jim's arm, and he is pulled underwater. He thinks of Norman, Sammy, Lizzie, and Sadie, before hallucinating John Locke again. The philosopher says Jim is in a never-ending war. Jim responds that, if this is true, he has the right to fight back and kill his enemy. Jim resurfaces, dragging the enormous catfish with him. Huck's excitement reminds Jim he is only a boy. Jim realizes he told Huck the truth for his own sake, to give the boy a choice.

The process of fighting the catfish recalls earlier chapters, when Huck and Jim were just friends to one another. Jim's struggle with the animal seems to represent the war John Locke describes, suggesting that subjugation does not imply superiority but merely indicates who won the fight. But Jim's reasoning—that he has the right to fight back in a war against his oppressors—makes Locke uncomfortable, exposing his true sentiment: that Black people should simply accept their situation and continue to submit to white people. By telling Huck about his true racial identity, Jim has given his son the freedom to choose for himself who he is going to be.



PART 3, CHAPTER 4

Jim and Huck set off down the river after dark, not speaking. Jim contemplates his anger, which has grown in scope and depth. They rest before heading inland, where they discover a well-trodden north-south trail. Hearing footsteps, they hide in the bushes and watch as a group of soldiers marches south. Huck is enthralled and wants to follow the men to whatever battle they are destined for. Jim does not consider the hypothetical war very important and wants to return Huck to Miss Watson and Judge Thatcher, where he will be safe. Huck tells Jim he doesn't own him—Jim hopes no one ever does.

It is possible Jim is beginning to realize that his performed submission and deference have not protected him, thereby increasing his anger. Huck's reaction to the soldiers confirms that he is still, in some ways, adventurous and innocent. Cynical as he is, Jim does not expect any good to come from the war, and he focuses his efforts on returning his son home safe. Huck's comment about ownership does not offend Jim, as his main desire is for Huck to maintain agency over his own life.



Jim's plan is to return Huck to town, find Sadie and Lizzie, and run to a free state. Huck wrestles with the feeling that he should be with his father—Jim—and his desire to see the adventure of war. Jim, who knows what it is like to face death every day, finds his romanticization childish, but he assures Huck there is no adventure in being a slave. Huck thinks he must have known Pap wasn't his real father and wishes Jim had told him the truth sooner. Jim claims he was trying to keep Huck safe, but this feels like a cliché. They continue to walk beside the river's shifting bank.

Although Jim cares deeply for Huck, he knows he will be safer passing as a white boy like he has done before. Huck is conflicted, feeling the need to ally himself with Jim, his father, but also desiring adventure. Whether Jim wishes Huck would come with him is left unclear.



PART 3, CHAPTER 5

Jim and Huck arrive back in Missouri. Huck accompanies Jim to his house, where two other enslaved people—Katie and Cotton—are now living. Doris tells Jim that Sadie and Lizzie were sold together. Jim breaks down, overcome by grief, and begs Huck for help. Huck insists he is only a boy, but Jim tells him he is a man after all he's gone through. He asks Huck to find Judge Thatcher and Miss Watson and find out who bought Sadie and Lizzie. Huck agrees to this new adventure, like the young boy he is. Katie and Cotton let Jim stay and rest in their house, even though he is a wanted man.

In the moment Jim is overcome by the loss of Sadie and Lizzie, Huck seems to fully see and accept Jim's humanity. He also appears to grasp the world's harshness and is overcome by feelings of helplessness. Nevertheless, Jim encourages his son to use his resources—his whiteness and his intelligence—to help him find his family. By placing his trust in Huck and affirming the boy's identity, Jim assures Huck that he values him as a loyal son.



PART 3, CHAPTER 6

Jim dreams of a white boy speaking to him in French about cultivating a garden. On second glance, he realizes the speaker is a woman who is not white. She mocks his hope to find his family, calling it a ruse. The woman also tells Jim no one wants him to be free because "people all over the world are making money off your scarred black hide." Her name is Cunégonde, a character from Voltaire's [Candide](#) (1759). Jim remarks that she still comes back at the end of the story, but Cunégonde is unimpressed.

Cunégonde is the love interest from Voltaire's 1759 novel [Candide](#); she represents an unattainable ideal. Since her discussion with Jim revolves around his enslavement and struggle for liberation, her presence suggests that his quest and hope for freedom is futile. Jim's observation that she returns at the end of Voltaire's novel (diminished and disappointing) suggests he has not given up hope, even if the freedom he finds is less than he desires.



When Jim wakes, Katie is telling him to hide. The overseer—Hopkins—enters the house. Cotton is out, but Hopkins has come for Katie. He rapes her while Jim watches, knowing that retaliating will make no difference in this moment, that Katie will still be constantly in danger. Instead, he befriends his anger, hoping to use it one day. Later, Jim leaves the house without telling anyone. He crosses the water to Jackson Island, where Huck will know to look for him. He steals some fish and makes a fire in their old cave. His **pencil** is still in his pocket.

Katie's rape is yet another example of racist dehumanization—Hopkins does not see her as a human being, so assaulting her is not problematic in his eyes. The futility of rescuing Katie without incurring further punishment for her and himself amplifies Jim's rage, though he is learning to save it for later use. He leaves the camp in order to protect the others from the consequences of his presence. Even alone, Jim clings to his pencil as the symbol of his hope.



PART 3, CHAPTER 7

The four days Jim spends on the island feel interminable. He is haunted by worry for his family and rage over Katie's rape. He hates himself for not intervening. One morning, Jim sees a single man on the beach: the overseer, Hopkins. He is drunk and alone. Jim remembers how Hopkins shot at the body of a young, lynched enslaved person. He steals Hopkins' gun before waking him from his stupor, speaking in slave diction before switching abruptly to normal speech. Jim strangles Hopkins, imploring him to think of all the women he has raped. Jim enjoys how little he cares in this moment, how Hopkins does not matter. He dumps the man's body in a canoe and sets it adrift.

Jim's reflections on the world's injustice still characterize him as disillusioned, but his anger at last pushes him toward action. When Hopkins arrives, Jim seizes the opportunity to right at least one wrong by killing the man. In his conversation with the overseer, Jim drops his performed dialect, revealing at once his intelligence and his humanity, both of which terrify Hopkins. The apathy he feels toward Hopkins at the moment of his death emphasizes that Jim's focus has shifted away from his oppressors and toward himself. In other words, rather than pursuing white approval or equality, Jim seeks justice for his own satisfaction.



PART 3, CHAPTER 8

Jim considers his act of revenge, but feels no guilt about it, only apathy. At last, Huck arrives on a Sunday, having snuck out of church. He has not admitted to seeing Jim, but he told Miss Watson and Judge Thatcher about his adventures with the King and the Duke. Hopkins told Huck that Lizzie and Sadie were taken to Graham farm before the overseer suddenly disappeared. Jim does not confess the murder to Huck, but he is frustrated with himself for not thinking to question the man before killing him. Huck is too young to fight in the war but has decided to side with the Union, who are against slavery. Jim thanks Huck and sends him back to the mainland.

Jim's lack of guilt frees him to consider what else he is capable of doing in order to save his family. Huck's loyalty to Jim, after all they have been through, speaks to his newly mature character. He seems to know this is the last time he will see Jim, and he assures his father that—although he is choosing to live under the safe cover of whiteness—he supports those who are fighting for Jim's freedom.



PART 3, CHAPTER 9

Jim swims back across the channel with rations, Hopkins' pistol, and his notebook. He sneaks into Judge Thatcher's library, searching for a map and a bill of sale for Sadie and Lizzie. Judge Thatcher interrupts and is shocked to see Jim pointing a pistol at him. Jim calls himself James and demands to know the location of his family. His natural speech baffles Thatcher, who cannot focus on what he is saying as much as how he is saying it. Finally, he tells Jim the Graham farm is in Edina, and marks it on a map. Thatcher declares that Jim cannot imagine the trouble he is in, which Jim finds ridiculous, knowing full well what horrible things white people are capable of.

In this climactic scene, Jim at last drops his performance of slave talk, as prioritizing white comfort has protected neither him nor his family. The act of renaming himself in front of a white person shows that he has fully abandoned his disguise and is now fully committed to self-determination. Judge Thatcher's shock illustrates how thoroughly he has convinced himself that Black people are unintelligent and subhuman. His attempts to reassert control over the situation presume that James is as simpleminded as he has been pretending to be—as James informs him, he is well aware of the trouble he is in, as he has frequently found himself in trouble for doing nothing at all.



James has never seen a white man as scared as Thatcher is, hearing an enslaved man speak in a language that does not conform to his expectations. Jim leads the judge to the river at gunpoint and forces him to row a skiff upriver. He calls Thatcher a slave and admits to murdering Hopkins for his gun. The fact that Jim is not afraid to tell Thatcher his crime scares the judge even more. Jim asks if Thatcher has ever raped a slave like Hopkins did. He has no interest in killing the judge but contradicts Thatcher's view of himself as a benevolent master. Thatcher calls Jim a racial slur and promises to see him dead.

Again, Thatcher's fear of James's speech highlights how Black intelligence causes white discomfort by forcing enslavers to reckon with the way they have abused other human beings. That James openly admits to the crime of murder indicates that he is no longer afraid of the consequences of his actions, making him all the more uncontrollable in Thatcher's eyes. By pushing back against Thatcher's insistence that he was a kind enslaver, James shatters the illusion of white innocence and asserts that loyalty cannot be coerced.



The sun rises and James forces Thatcher to row them to shore. He sets the boat adrift and ties the judge to a tree, leaving him ungagged. Thatcher asks what **books** James has taken from his library, which surprises James. He has taken a slave narrative, *Candide*, and some John Stuart Mill. Thatcher seems even more offended and insists that James can't leave him like this. When James asks if he means alive, the judge is silent. Thatcher tells James he will not make it to Edina, and James agrees that is a possibility.

The judge's question about his book seems less like genuine interest and more like he is calling James' bluff, asking him to prove he can read. As expected, he is appalled to discover that James is telling the truth about his literacy, as it contradicts his expectations about Black intelligence. That James leaves Thatcher alive shames the judge, who knows James has shown him more mercy than he would if their positions were reversed.



PART 3, CHAPTER 10

James walks quickly in the direction of Edina. He encounters a Black man in a cornfield who tells him the Graham farm is a breeding farm. The man and his wife feed James before he sets off again. Reaching Edina, he finds four slaves shackled to a post near the slave quarters. They are chained up like animals to promote animalistic breeding. James frees the men and asks after Lizzie and Sadie. He invites them to either run or help him retrieve his family from the women's camp. The men find his lack of plan crazy, but James has no time. He introduces himself as James, and the other men state their names before joining him.

The kindness shown by the Black couple demonstrates how solidarity between people in similar circumstances is key for surviving an oppressive world. The way the enslaved men have been chained like animals supports the enslaver's dehumanizing perceptions of Black people and encourages them to think of themselves in similar terms. James respects the men's ability to exercise agency and choose their own path. In joining his cause, the men exhibit the powerful camaraderie that exists between people who have experienced oppression in similar ways.



PART 3, CHAPTER 11

James and the other men approach the women's quarters, which are guarded by a white overseer. He tells the men they will take everyone here north with them, and he instructs one man to take out the overseer. James uses a match to light the dry cornfield ablaze, provoking screams from the plantation house. In front of one shack, James sees Sadie and runs to her. Lizzie is with her, and the family reunite in disbelief. The enslaved people run past the fire and the old enslaver, who is shouting at them to help. James cocks his pistol at the man, declares himself "the angel of death [...] James," and shoots him dead. James runs with Sadie and Lizzie up the road.

The plantation's lax security suggests the enslavers believe their slaves are too submissive to revolt. James's journey culminates here with the successful reunion of his family. The enslaver's demands for help presume those he has enslaved will remain loyal to him. Having dropped all pretense of ignorance and simplicity, James responds to the man by reasserting his own chosen identity, emphasizing that he is no longer sacrificing his personhood for the comfort of others.



PART 3, CHAPTER 12

The runaways scatter. James speculates that some are killed or captured or return to their owners. He, Sadie, Lizzie, and a few of the men who helped them escape make their way to a town in Iowa. With the war raging, the white people there have no choice but to accept them. The local sheriff asks if any of them goes by Jim, using the n-word before his name. When everyone else is introduced, Jim responds to the sheriff "I am James. [...] Just James."

The novel suggests that James and his family's reception in the northern free states is less than welcoming, likely indicating that even the white people who support abolition still deny Black people's humanity to some extent. But James is mainly focused on the fact that he has successfully reunited with his family and has constructed a new identity for himself. In leaving behind his old name and claiming a new one, James denies his enslavers the ability to define him, and he thus concludes his self-written narrative.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Bounds, Aimee. "James." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 17 May 2024. Web. 29 May 2024.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Bounds, Aimee. "James." LitCharts LLC, May 17, 2024. Retrieved May 29, 2024. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/james>.

To cite any of the quotes from *James* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Everett, Percival. James. Doubleday. 2024.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Everett, Percival. James. New York: Doubleday. 2024.